SPREAD LOVE & ACCEPTANCE · BOOK 4

Share the Load

The work nobody sees, and
a fair, kind way to share it



by Christian

Independently published
spreadloveandacceptance.com

Spread Love & Acceptance, Book 4: *Share the Load*.
By Christian. Independently published.

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Free online, always. Every chapter of the series is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, in a short and a full version, with no account and no paid version. The print books are optional. You may copy pages of this book for personal use and for non-commercial teaching, with credit to "Spread Love & Acceptance, spreadloveandacceptance.com."

Not therapy. This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counselor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

The examples are made up. The people in this book's examples are made up; any likeness to real people is coincidence. None of them is a testimonial.

The research the chapters mention is listed briefly at the back. The full list, with what each study found and links, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

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About this book, and how to use it

This book is about the work of sharing a life: the jobs nobody sees, a simple check of whether the way you share them can last, how much of a reaction is leftover stress, two kinds of fair, and a gentle monthly look back.

It is for anyone who shares a home, a family or a job, whether that is a couple, a family, roommates, co-parents or coworkers. Most of it also works if you are the only one reading.

Read the chapters in any order. Each is a short version of a chapter that is free to read online, where the full version has more research, more examples and more to try. The code at the end of each chapter opens it on your phone.

HERE	ABOUT	FREE ONLINE AT SPREADLOVEANDACCEPTANCE.COM/BOOK
Chapter 1	The work nobody sees	…/book/preface
Chapter 2	Is the split working?	…/book/chapter-2
Chapter 3	Full tanks and different angles	…/book/chapter-3
Chapter 4	Two kinds of fair	…/book/chapter-4
Chapter 5	The monthly look-back	…/book/chapter-5
Afterword	What the series adds up to	…/book/afterword

Each book in the series stands on its own. Book 1, *Know Yourself Kindly*, is about yourself. Book 2, *Heal and Steady*, is about the heavy days. Book 3, *Understanding Each Other*, is about understanding the people around you. When a chapter mentions another book, it gives the book, the chapter and the page in that book, as in "Book 2, Chapter 1 (page 7)." The workbook, The Workpapers, has every form from the series on big pages.

FIVE BIG IDEAS

Five ideas run under the whole series.

- **See the whole load.** Count the unseen work too, the noticing, remembering and planning, yours and other people's.
- **Fix the setup, not the person.** When something keeps going wrong, change the arrangement around it before you blame anyone.
- **Read your state first.** How full your day already is changes how every word sounds, so check yourself before you react.
- **Tune how you send and receive.** People differ in pace, tone and wiring, and a mismatch is something to translate, never a fault.
- **Notice the quiet incentives.** Jobs nobody owns drift to whoever notices first, and a named owner and a real thank-you stop the drift.

Some chapters mention the six-week program, a free plan on the website with one small step a week (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01). The workbook has a planner for it. The people in this book's examples are made up; any likeness to real people is coincidence.

Find it fast

Start with what is going on. Each line points to the chapter that helps most, and you can read that chapter on its own.

One of you feels they do everything	Chapter 1 · The work nobody sees	7
You want a fair check of how the work is shared	Chapter 2 · Is the split working?	27
A new baby or small children have changed everything	Chapter 2 · Is the split working?	27
Small things turn into big fights	Chapter 3 · Full tanks and different angles	51
You disagree about what fair means	Chapter 4 · Two kinds of fair	73
Money is a sore point between you	Chapter 4 · Two kinds of fair	73
The same problem keeps coming back	Chapter 5 · The monthly look-back	97
Only one of you wants to try	Chapter 2 · Is the split working?	27

Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-01 **A workpaper** is a page you fill in, on your own or together, such as "Workpaper WP-01: Who did what." Every workpaper is free to print or to fill out on the website, and the book gives a code to scan for each one. *The Workpapers: The Bound Edition* has them all in one place, on big pages.

TOOL **A tool** is a helper you use on the website, such as "Tool: Who does what? Quick look." You use it and it gives you something back.

Workpapers and tools are kept in separate lists. Both are free and need no account, and what you type stays on your own device.

THREE FRIENDS WHO GIVE HINTS



Professor Puddles, a raindrop in a mortarboard, gives most of the hints, and answers questions on the website.



Tidbit, the quick, curious pup, points you at something to try.



Sugarfoot, the slower, steadier pup, turns up when a page needs a calmer pace.

They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.

FROM THE PERSON WHO MADE THIS

> *"I spent my career as a government auditor and audit manager in tax enforcement, internal controls and compliance." "Everyone else seemed to have been handed a set of instructions about being human that nobody ever gave me, so I went looking for them myself." "Everything here exists so that you can do the same thing in far less time than it took me."*

Christian, quoted from the About page at spreadloveandacceptance.com/about. Where the chapters say "I," they speak for the website and these books; any fact about Christian in them comes from that page.

1

BOOK 4 · CHAPTER 1

The work nobody sees: invisible labor at home

Running a shared life takes a lot of work that nobody sees. This opening chapter helps you make that work visible, to yourself and to anyone you share it with, so that you can talk about it fairly and kindly.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Unseen work quietly adds up
2. A lot of it is thinking, not doing
3. The other person usually just hasn't seen it
4. Writing it down isn't keeping score
5. Each of you writes only your own side
6. The borrowed words are there to take the blame away
7. One small step at a time
8. It can help in many kinds of shared life
9. The mental load: what the research says
10. On your own: your own unseen work
11. One household, followed for a month
12. Your situation, chapter by chapter
13. Common mix-ups
14. Limits and cautions

AT A GLANCE

- **Running a home takes unseen work**, the noticing, remembering and planning that many people call the mental load.
- **The other person usually just hasn't seen it.** This work hides by nature, and missing it says little about how much someone cares.

- **Each of you writes only your own side** of one ordinary week, and you read the two lists together.
- **The list is for seeing.** Thank each other for the past, and plan next week.

SUNDAY, 9PM

The laundry has been in the machine since Saturday morning and will need doing again, because it has that smell. The school trip form is due Tuesday. The birthday card for Auntie Jean is on the hall table, still in its cellophane, unsigned. Somebody in the house has noticed all three of these things, and it is probably you.

Somebody has also noticed that nobody else has noticed. From the hallway the house looks fine, which is exactly the trouble.

Kin work

The anthropologist Micaela di Leonardo called the cards, calls, visits and presents that keep a wider family connected "kin work." In the families she studied it was done mostly by women and treated as if it took no effort at all. The unsigned card on the hall table is a small piece of it.

di Leonardo (1987) · *Moderate: an influential qualitative study*

Quickly: a birthday card on the hall table is the surface. Underneath, the noticing that it needs signing. Underneath that, a whole list held in one head. The roots are balance and limited capacity. The chapters that follow slow down on each part.

01

Unseen work quietly adds up.

Remembering appointments, noticing the milk is low, calming a tense moment before it turns into a fight. None of it shows up on a calendar, so it rarely gets a thank-you, and over months it piles up. This book calls the pile *unbilled debt*, because nobody ever sends a

bill for it. (It's a ledger word, and I make no apology for it. I spent my career as a government auditor, where a control is just an agreement about how a thing gets done, who owns it and how anyone would notice if it stopped. Who notices that the milk is low is a control in your home too, and if it only works because the same person quietly catches it every time, it was never really set up.) You can thank someone for what they carried before, and you leave the past unbilled.

Marcus remembers every school form, every dentist appointment and every bit of lunch money for their two children. His husband, Theo, sees two children who always seem to have what they need, gym clothes included, and genuinely has no idea how. When Marcus went to Baltimore for three days in March, Theo found out. Both children went to school on non-uniform day in uniform, and one of them went without a coat. Theo called Marcus on the second night and said, "How do you *know*?" He isn't careless, and never was; the work had simply been out of his sight for eleven years.

The second shift

Arlie Hochschild's interviews and home visits with working couples found mothers doing far more of the housework and childcare, a second shift on top of the paid one, and many couples telling themselves a story in which the split was fair. Large time-use surveys since show the gap persisting, and narrowing.

Hochschild with Machung (1989) · *Moderate: an influential qualitative study; its figures describe its own sample*



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Write down one ordinary week. Only your own jobs, and the thinking counts too. Most people are surprised by their own list.

WORKPAPER WP-01 **Who did what** · free to print · spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-01 · free to print
Who did what
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01

02

A lot of it is thinking, not doing.

Before a job gets done, someone has to notice it, remember it, plan it and check that it happened. That thinking takes real time and energy, though nobody can see it. In a shared apartment above a laundromat, Yasmin noticed the broadband deal ended in three weeks. She compared six plans on a spreadsheet, picked one, set it up, and checked the next morning that it had gone through. Paying took two minutes, while the thinking took most of a Thursday evening, and as far as she knows nobody else in the apartment has any idea it happened. When the internet kept working, one of them said, "Oh good, the broadband's fine."

Four parts of the thinking

Interviewing 35 couples, Allison Daminger split household thinking work into anticipating needs, identifying options, deciding and monitoring. Women in the study did more of it overall, especially the anticipating and the monitoring, deciding was shared more equally, and much of it went unseen by both partners.

Daminger (2019) · *Moderate: a rich interview study of mostly college-educated couples; not population figures*

Pick one job at home and split it into its steps (noticing, planning, doing, checking), then ask who usually does each one.

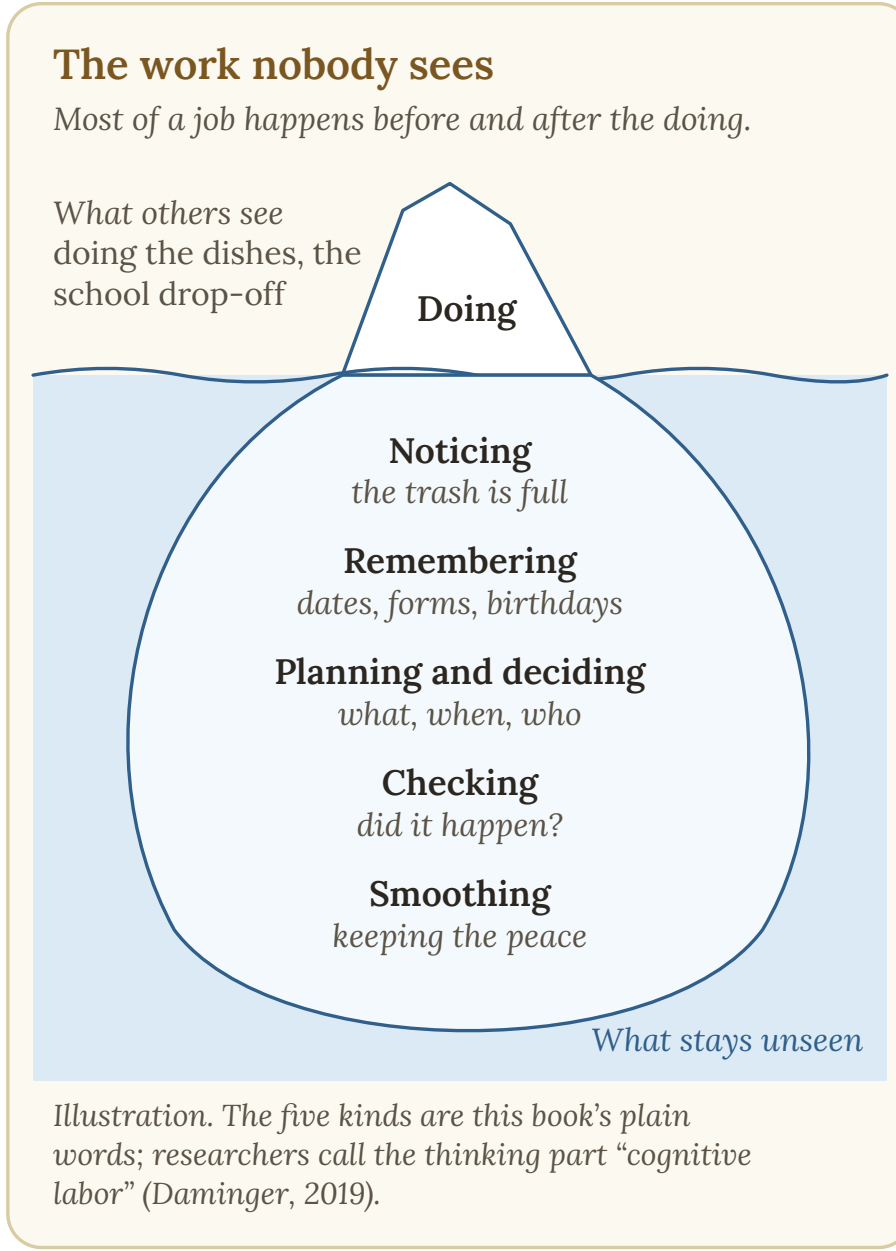


FIGURE 1 The work nobody sees. Most of a job happens before and after the doing, and whoever holds that part can never fully switch off.

03

The other person usually just hasn't seen it.

When this work is done well, nothing seems to happen, so the other person is rarely ignoring it. From where they stand, things look as though they take care of themselves. Edna minds her grandchildren three afternoons a week and quietly moves her own hospital appointments to fit, and her daughter thinks it all slots in easily. It doesn't. Edna has canceled her eye clinic twice. A gentle question often opens it up ("What's something you do that you think I don't see?"), followed by listening without explaining.

Sometimes it only becomes visible when the person who carried it has gone. Over his first winter alone, a widower found out how many jobs his wife had quietly held, from the birthday cards and the water heater service to knowing who to call when someone was ill. He didn't see any of it until it stopped getting done, and the water heater broke in January. If that's where you are, the section for people on their own, further on in this chapter, was written with you in mind.

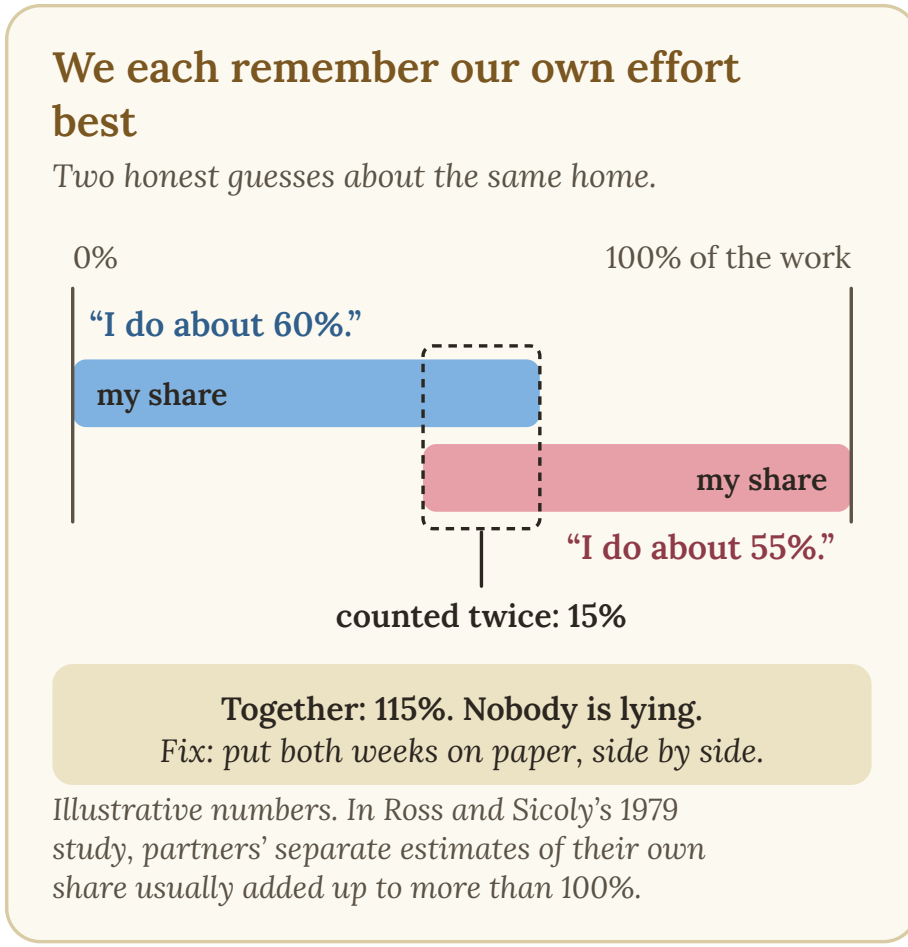


FIGURE 2 We each remember our own effort best. Illustrative numbers. In Ross and Sicoly's 1979 study, partners' estimates of their own share usually added up to more than 100 percent.

04

Writing it down isn't keeping score.

The point is for both of you to see the same picture, in the same words, at the same time, so the talk starts from facts you share. This book calls that shared record a *ledger*, a plain list of who did what, kept for seeing.

Two colleagues who job-share each listed a week of tasks. It turned out every single difficult client call had landed on Tamsin, every one of them, and nobody had decided that. It had just happened, the way these things do, because she was better at them. They left last year alone and agreed to take turns with Friday calls. A quick look at who does what is a gentle place to start. Before you show anyone a list, ask yourself honestly whether it's to plan next week or to prove a point. If it's the second, keep it in the drawer for now.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

Who did what

Marcus and Theo, a couple

Who did what

Person A
Marcus

Person B
Theo

Week beginning
October 5, 2026

Part A: Who did what, this week

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Mon	*Plan the week's meals*	*Theo*	20	*Thinking and planning*
Mon	*Cook dinner*	*Marcus*	45	*Asked for*
Tue	*Book the water heater service*	*Theo*	15	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Dishes*	*Marcus*	20	*Asked for*
Wed	*Laundry, wash to put away*	*Theo*	60	*Noticed and handled*

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Thu	*Remember Marcus's mom's birthday card*	*Theo*	*10*	*Thinking and planning*
Fri	*Trash and recycling out*	*Marcus*	*10*	*Noticed and handled*
Sat	*Big food shop*	*Both*	*70*	*Asked for*

THIS WEEK'S TOTALS

Marcus
110 minutes (44%), of which 10 noticed and handled without being asked

Theo
140 minutes (56%), of which 105 noticed and handled without being asked (30 of them thinking and planning)

Workload balance score
0.88. It describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it.

Unasked-for work
Theo did 91% of the work that was noticed and handled without anyone asking. This is the work that is easiest to miss. Say it out loud, and give the jobs that repeat a named owner.

Part B (optional): Kind ways to say no

Left blank this week.
Fill in your own: Who did what

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Who does what? Quick look
spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand



WORKPAPER WP-01 · free to print
Who did what
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01

05

Each of you writes only your own side.

Nobody fills in anything for the other person. You each note what you did and then read the two lists together, which keeps it fair and keeps it kind. Each of you also adds the context only you have, a long week at work, children off school with colds, so you both understand what you read.

Arran, Dani and Sol are three partners sharing a rented house in Leith. Each wrote only their own list, in their own handwriting, which in Dani's case needed some translating. Reading them together at the kitchen table, Sol learned for the first time that Arran had called the landlord about the damp every single month since February. "Every month?" said Sol. "Every month," said Arran. Dani said, "I thought it had just stopped." It hadn't; it had spread behind the wardrobe.

06

The borrowed words are there to take the blame away.

The book uses a few terms from accounting and science because they describe what is happening without saying whose fault it is. Each one is explained in plain words, and you never need them to use anything here.

Two brothers share their mom's care, and one of them had been about to say "You never help" for about a year. What he said in the end was "There's some work here neither of us has looked at properly." His brother, braced for a fight, found he didn't need to have one. If words like "ledger" or "debt" feel heavy, use your own. "Our list" and "the stuff nobody sees" do the same job.

07

One small step at a time.

Each chapter adds one idea and one tool, and one week of notes is enough to start. Later come a 90-second daily check-in about how much you were carrying that day, and a monthly look-back that needs only a few lines a week. Precious is a nurse on nights and her partner works days, and they hardly see each other awake. They started with one week of notes stuck to the fridge with a magnet from Whitby, and changed nothing at all for a week. That was the whole plan. Your first step can be as small as picking a start day and setting one reminder.

08

It can help in many kinds of shared life.

Partners, families, roommates, co-parents and coworkers all share unseen work. The examples often use a couple at home, and the ideas fit anyone who shares a load. In a foster home, the caregiver keeps track of family visits and social worker calls, while a fifteen-year-old in the home quietly cooks for the younger ones twice a week, usually pasta, and both kinds of work deserve counting.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't make anyone see the unseen work, and you can't write their side of the ledger. You can write your own side honestly, say it once, kindly, and then match what you take on to what comes back. If you keep carrying more than your share with nothing in return, stepping back toward your share isn't a punishment. It protects the energy you need to stay kind. More in Your wiring, weather and words (Book 1, Chapter 2, page 25)

FRIDAY, AFTER WORK

"You didn't have to do all that," they say, and they mean it kindly.

Someone did, though. The list only ever lived in your head, so to them it looked as if it took care of itself, the way a house seems to clean itself if you're never in it on a Saturday morning. You don't say this. You say "It's fine," which it isn't, quite.

The mental load: what the research says

Many people call the thinking side of home life the **mental load**, meaning the noticing and planning that come before a job gets done and the checking after. It includes knowing the baby needs the next size of clothes, and remembering the form and the party present. It is real work, even when it doesn't look like any.

Studies of couples find some patterns, *on average*. In couples of a man and a woman, women tend to do more of the noticing and checking (Allison Daminger, 2019). After a first baby a gap often opens, and in one study of working couples, mothers took on most of the new childcare while keeping their paid hours (Jill Yavorsky

and colleagues, 2015). Arlie Hochschild called the home work that starts after paid work ends "the second shift."

There is a fair point on the other side too. Sometimes the parent who knows how things are done holds on to that, without meaning to, which researchers call *gatekeeping*. When a parent openly invites the other in and lets them do it their own way, the other parent tends to do more of the care (Sarah Allen and Alan Hawkins, 1999; Sarah Schoppe-Sullivan and colleagues, 2008).

These are averages across many homes, and they say nothing certain about yours. In your home it may be the other way round, or already even, or shared between two men or two women, which is why the book asks you to look at your own week on paper instead of guessing.

Hollie and Gareth have a toddler and a baby, and Gareth works shifts. Their week's minutes come out nearly even, yet Hollie did almost three-quarters of the jobs nobody asked anyone to do. Their week is in Chapter 2 (page 43).

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "You do lots of the doing. It's the remembering I'd love you to take some of, whole jobs, start to finish." Or the other way round, "Show me once how you like it done, then let me do it my way."

On your own: your own unseen work

You don't need anyone else to start seeing it. For one week, notice the jobs only you remember (the appointments, the smoothing-over) and write them down for yourself. Count it without charging for it. The point is to see your real load so you can plan your

energy. Notice which jobs are yours by choice and which just landed on you, and pick one you could hand back or do less often.

Nicola has the children every other week. Four years after the divorce, she sat down with a pen and found she was still buying the birthday presents for both sides of the family. His mom, his sister's twins and his godson in Portland were all still on her list. She handed his side back in one friendly message, and braced herself. He replied with a thumbs-up and, to her surprise, "fair enough." More for people living alone or after a breakup is on the On my own page.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

One household, followed for a month

Three grown-up siblings share the care of their dad, who lives on his own in the house they grew up in. On paper the visits are split evenly, two days each. When each of them wrote a week of their own side, the picture changed. Ffion, the eldest, also held the prescriptions, the hospital letters and the calls to the doctor, none of which counted as a visit. Their brother was surprised and a bit defensive, and the first conversation ended early, with someone leaving to "check the car." A month later they tried again. He took over the prescriptions completely, with the reminders on his own phone. Their sister still finds the hospital letters too much to face, so Ffion keeps those for now, and they've agreed to look again in

the spring. Help by relationship has a page for many other kinds of shared life.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

Your situation, chapter by chapter

Some situations get their own section:

- **Faith, culture, elders and in-laws.** Book 3, Chapter 1 (page 7)
- **Small children or a new baby.** Chapter 2 (page 43)
- **Two homes after a split, and step-parents.** Chapter 3 (page 67)
- **Money between you, and a couple with a roommate.** Chapter 4 (page 90)
- **New together, or grandparents raising a grandchild.** Chapter 5 (page 113)

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

Doing everything at the last minute

FROM OUTSIDE The form had a month. It gets done the night before.

THE LOGIC Interest and urgency switch the engine on. A far-off deadline doesn't. The deadline arriving finally does. So late work is more a starting problem than a caring problem.

IT'S LIKE A car that only starts when you roll it down a hill.

WHY IT FITS For many people with ADHD, starting depends on urgency more than on importance.

THE OTHER SIDE The other person carries the worry of not knowing, which is invisible work too.

YOU COULD SAY "*I care about this. My brain starts late.*"

ONE SMALL STEP Set an earlier, shared check-in date the other person can count on.

BOTH DIRECTIONS Some people start a task as soon as it appears, and a form left for a month feels like a weight. Others find that interest and urgency switch the engine on, and a far-off deadline simply doesn't. If you start early, the night-before person usually does care. Their brain starts late. If you're the late starter, agreeing on an earlier "pretend deadline" together takes the worry off the other person without asking you to change how you work.

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET Finance calls this unbilled debt: every entry has two sides, and work nobody sees still goes in the ledger. Economics adds that attention is a budget, and business that work belonging to everyone belongs to no one.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
`spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=last-minute`

Common mix-ups

"If it mattered, they'd have asked for help" misses how hidden this work is, often from the person doing it, until it's written down. Nobody needs exactly 50/50, either. What you're after is a split you can both see and both agree to. Please don't start by going

over the last ten years. Start with one ordinary week, and thank each other for the past without trying to settle it. And the one doing less usually isn't the one who cares less. Usually they just can't see it yet, and once you've both seen it, what happens next is a choice you make together.

To start, each of you can list the things you did this week that nobody saw, then swap lists and read the other one slowly. Say one thing on it you hadn't noticed. Pick one item and thank them for it in a specific way. If writing things down isn't your style, a ten-minute talk over a coffee with the same questions works too. Fixing comes later. Who did what turns this into a gentle week-long log, and How to say a specific thank-you has more ideas.

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-01 · free to print
Who did what
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01



ONLINE
How to say a specific thank-you
spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward

Limits and cautions

A shared list and keeping tabs on someone can look alike on paper. A shared list is something you both chose. Each of you writes your own side, and either of you can stop. Keeping tabs is one person asking for the other's notes, checking them, or using them to track where the other goes or what they spend. Some people just like a lot of detail, and that's fine when it's about their own side. If a list starts to feel like the second kind, set it aside and talk about how it's being used before you go back to it.

If you are a counselor or group leader using this book with others, see For counselors.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
For counselors
spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 2 · Is the split working? page 27
Putting the unseen work into numbers you both trust

Book 3, Chapter 3 · How we see each other Understanding Each Other, page 45
Why each person sees their own work first

Book 3, Chapter 7 · Helping others well Understanding Each Other, page 113
Care work and how not to burn out

Chapter 4 · Two kinds of fair page 73
What fair means to each of you, before you talk

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 1: see the work that's already happening

spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

Who did what

Workpaper · free to print

spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/preface-in-depth

2

BOOK 4 · CHAPTER 2

Is the split working? A fair look at chores at home

One gentle question: can the way you share the work keep going, or is one of you quietly running on empty?

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Look at the month, not last night
2. Three things go in
3. Balance: how the hours split
4. Ownership: does each job have a name?
5. Stress: how full each stress tank is
6. One number comes out, from 0 to 1
7. Start with the biggest shortfall
8. It judges the setup, never a person
9. Words this chapter uses
10. On your own: is your own load working?
11. One setup, looked at twice
12. Common mix-ups
13. Small children and a new baby
14. If only one of you wants to try this
15. More for your situation

ANY GIVEN WEEK

One of you is quietly doing eleven small things a day that the other has never had to think about, like the trash schedule and the fish food, the reply to the school, the dentist reminder, and the bit at the bottom of the shopping list that just says "bulbs?"

When the other one says it feels pretty even, they mean it. From inside their own week, it does.

Eleven small jobs a day, seen quickly. On the surface, a split that feels even to one person. Underneath, jobs with no owner.

Underneath that, stress tanks at very different levels. The roots are ownership and structure, and quiet incentives. Then the chapter takes the three parts of the score in turn.

01

Look at the month, not last night.

Ask whether the split is working and the answer usually comes from whatever happened most recently, which is usually last night's pans. This chapter asks a calmer question, using what you both wrote down. Ask it again every few months, even when things seem fine, because a split that worked once can quietly go stale.

Two roommates had one truly terrible week of dishes in May, the kind where you wash a fork in order to eat with it. They were all set for a big fight. Then they looked at the whole month, written down, and it was three ordinary weeks and one exam week. The fight didn't happen, which was almost a disappointment after all that build-up. They bought paper plates for exam week and left it at that.



SUGARFOOT

One bad evening isn't the whole story. Give it a month, then run the check together, slowly, with something to eat.

TOOL **Fair split check: this week** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Fair split check: this week
spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working

02

Three things go in.

The first is how evenly the hours are shared. The second is whether every regular job has a clear owner, from the job list in One owner per job. The third is how stressed each of you already is from everything else going on. A **workpaper** is one of the site's free fill-in worksheets. You don't need any of them to start, since rough notes on the back of an envelope do fine.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "Let's each bring our own numbers, so neither of us has to guess."

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

03

Balance: how the hours split.

From your week-long logs, work out each person's share of the hours. An even split scores 1 and one person doing everything scores 0, whichever person it is. If you've agreed an uneven split that suits you, perhaps because one of you works longer hours outside the home, compare against that split instead. With three or more of you, compare each person's share with an even share (100 divided by the number of people) or with the split you agreed. Three partners who log 30 hours of home jobs between them, at 15, 9 and 6, would each have 10 as an even share. The "Who does

what?" page, where each person lists their hours, does the arithmetic for you.

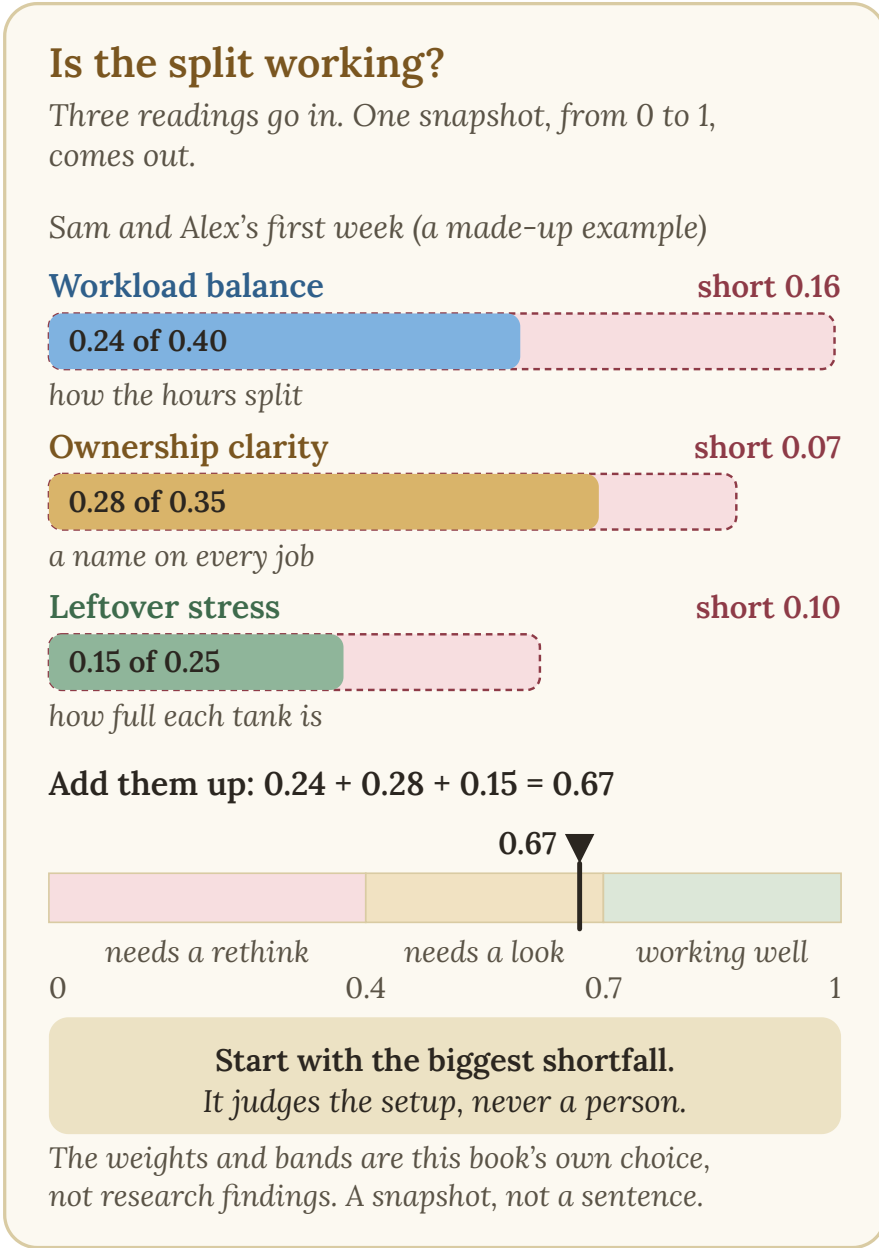


FIGURE 3 Is the split working? Three readings go in and one snapshot comes out. Start with the biggest shortfall. It judges the setup, never a person.

Log one week each, and put in the small jobs that take under ten minutes. Those are the ones that go missing. They are often the ones that start the fights, too.

Everyone's share comes to more than 100%

In a classic set of experiments, spouses asked for their own share of joint jobs gave answers that, added together, usually came to more than 100%. Nobody was lying. We simply remember our own contributions better, which is the best argument I know for writing the week down instead of guessing.

Ross and Sicoly (1979) · *Strong: a classic, widely replicated finding*

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

Who does what? Quick look

Wren, Josh and Mei, roommates (Wren's view)

Quick look: who does what at home

Mark who mostly does each job. The picture builds as you go, the thinking work too.

Your name
Wren

Their name
Josh

Person 3
Mei

Job	Who mostly does it
Dishes	*Shared*
Laundry	*Shared*
Cleaning the bathroom	*Josh*
Cooking dinner	*Mei*
Grocery shopping	*Wren*
Paying bills	*Wren*
Noticing what's running low	*Wren*

Job	Who mostly does it
Planning the week	*Mei*
Remembering dates and appointments	*Wren*

HOW IT LOOKS

Here's how it looks from your side, 9 jobs so far.

Everyday jobs: mostly shared. 6 jobs: Wren 2 · Josh 1 · Mei 1 · Shared 2.

Planning and remembering: mostly Wren. 3 jobs: Wren 2 · Mei 1.

The thinking work is easy to miss, because nobody sees it happen. Saying it out loud is a good start.

Does this match how it feels to the three of you?

Pets and booking appointments were taken off the list: they don't happen in this house.

Fill in your own: Who does what? Quick look

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Who does what? Count the hours and bills
spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand

04

Ownership: does each job have a name?

Each job gets two names. The owner does the job from start to finish. The backstop notices if it slipped and checks in gently, which is very different from supervising. It can be the same

person, though a second name gives the job a gentle check. Count the jobs that have an owner and divide by all the jobs on the list, and leave the unowned jobs on the list, because they matter most. A *decision* you make together, such as which school, can be marked “Both (decide together)” and counts as owned. A *job* that needs doing gets one name.

Most of what goes wrong in shared work isn’t incompetence. It’s unclear ownership: work that belongs to everyone belongs to no one, and it quietly lands on whoever notices first.

Two sisters care for their dad. Nobody owned his repeat prescription. For two weeks each of them thought the other had ordered it, and each, it turned out, had thought about ringing to check and hadn’t, so as not to seem pushy. He ran out on a Sunday. The out-of-hours pharmacy was forty minutes away.

05

Stress: how full each stress tank is.

Each of you rates how full your own stress tank is with How much are you carrying?, where a higher score means more stress. Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 up to 0.60 is medium, and 0.60 or more is high. The score uses the average of your two scores, but if either of you is at 0.60 or more, talk about that first, even when the overall result looks fine. A setup that only works when you’re both well rested can’t last, so more stress lowers the result.

Doreen is raising her two grandchildren and scores 0.70. Her son, who helps on weekends, scores 0.35. The average looks fine, but Doreen’s 0.70 is the headline, whatever the average says, and her son, looking at the two numbers side by side, went quiet for a long time. Each of you scores your own tank on the same day, before you look at the other’s.

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER
WP-02 · free to print
How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

How loaded it feels

The Perceived Stress Scale, one of the most used stress questionnaires, asks how unpredictable, uncontrollable and overloaded life has felt lately, and its scores track symptoms of depression and illness. That's close to what the stress tank asks: not how much happened, but how loaded it feels.

Cohen, Kamarck and Mermelstein (1983) · *Strong: one of the most widely used stress questionnaires*

06

One number comes out, from 0 to 1.

A result of 0.70 or above reads as *working well*, meaning the setup is holding. From 0.40 up to 0.70 it reads as *needs a look*, because something is drifting, often who owns what, and below 0.40 it reads as *needs a rethink, together*. The result is called the setup score. It is a simple weighted sum, in which the hours count most, then the owners, then stress, and although it looks like a probability it isn't one.

Two friends who run a café together scored 0.55. So nothing was broken, just something drifting, and it took them about four minutes to find it, which was the Monday ordering. Each of them had assumed for months that the other did it, and it had been getting done, more or less, by whoever panicked first on Tuesday morning. Write the date next to your number, so you can compare next month.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

Is the setup working for everyone?

Rosemary and Ken, retired, married 41 years

Is the setup working for everyone?

Person 1 (optional)
Rosemary

Person 2 (optional)
Ken

1. How the hours split

From Who did what or the "Who does what?" page: each person's total hours for the week.

Rosemary, hours
14

Ken, hours
10

2. Does each job have a name?

From One owner per job.

Jobs on the list
12

Jobs with an owner
9

3. How much each person is carrying

Each person's own score from How much are you carrying? Everyone fills in their own.

Rosemary, load (0 to 1)
0.45

Ken, load (0 to 1)
0.30

HOW THE SETUP IS WORKING

Working well
0.75 of 1. The setup is carrying its own weight.

Next: nothing in the setup needs changing this week. Keep the same rhythm of check-ins.

If you want to nudge it higher one day (optional, not urgent): hand about 2 hours a week from Rosemary to Ken, and balance would go from 0.83 to 1.00. Give one more job an owner (the person who does it and sees it through), and ownership would go from 0.75 to 0.83.

It scores the setup, never a person, and never the relationship as a whole.

Fill in your own: Is the setup working for everyone?

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Fair split check: this week
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/calculators/is-the-setup-working-quick

07

Start with the biggest shortfall.

The single number matters less than which of the three parts pulled it down most. The **shortfall** is how far one part fell below the most it could add, and in the middle band it's often ownership, which is why the calculator suggests One owner per job first. A separated couple scored 0.62 and found their biggest gap was that nobody owned the school forms. That was the only thing they changed that month, and both of them were quietly relieved it wasn't something bigger.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"Which part pulled the number down most? Let's start there."

08

It judges the setup, never a person.

The number isn't a verdict on who's better or whether the relationship works. It's where a conversation starts, never how one ends.

"So I'm the problem," said Lee, looking at 0.35.

"No," said his partner. "The bathroom hasn't got an owner and you work nights."

When a measure becomes a target

Goodhart's law, from an economist writing about monetary policy, says a number tends to stop telling you anything once people are pushed to hit it. That's the reason this score is for looking at together and never for winning.

Goodhart (1975) · *Moderate: an economist's observation, later generalized and widely seen in practice*

They started there. Before you begin, agree that either of you can say "pause" and come back later.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. The score describes the setup you share, but your levers are your own: your jobs, your hours and what you agree to take on. You can propose a fix; you can't make the other person accept it. If the balance stays one-sided, step your load back toward your share on purpose, and say so kindly. Matching effort with effort protects your stress tank, and your tank is part of the score too. More in Your wiring, weather and words (Book 1, Chapter 2, page 25)

SUNDAY EVENING

Two week-long logs. Two cups of tea. One list has 31 rows and the other has 18, and for a moment neither of you says anything and the fridge hums.

"I honestly didn't know about half of these," one of you says.

"Which half?"

Words this chapter uses

A **log** is a simple list of the jobs you did this week and roughly how long each took. The **owner** does a job from start to finish, including remembering it, and the **backstop** notices if a job slipped and checks in gently. Your **stress tank** is how much stress you're already carrying from the rest of life. The **setup** is the way you share the work right now, which can always be changed, and the **setup score** is the one number from 0 to 1 that sums up the three readings. Invisible jobs count too. Planning meals, remembering birthdays, booking the vet and noticing that the soap is running low all belong in your log.

On your own: is your own load working?

You can ask the same question of your own week. Are you spending more energy than comes back? Add up what you carry, jobs and worries both, and set it beside what refills you. If it runs in the red, change your side, by dropping, delaying, asking or saying no kindly. A limit describes your supply. It says nothing about your worth. After her breakup, Leanne had the children every other week and filled the quiet weeks with favors for friends, including one memorable assemble-it-yourself wardrobe that took

nine hours and a hospital visit (her thumb). Writing it down showed her she never rested (more in On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

WORDS TO TRY

"I'd love to help, and I can't this week. Can I let you know next week?"

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

One setup, looked at twice

Three people share an apartment above a bakery, and everyone agrees that cleaning matters while nobody owns the bathroom. Their first check scores 0.67, and the biggest shortfall is ownership: eight of the twelve jobs have a name, and the bathroom, the trash, the recycling and the hallway don't. They give each of those four jobs an owner and a backstop. A month later, with the hours and their stress tanks about the same as before, the score is 0.79. Ownership went from 0.67 to 1.00, and that part counts for 0.35 of the score, so it adds 0.12. The bathroom is better. The recycling is still a sore point, because the one who owns it works late on collection night, and that's the job they're arguing about next. Shift work, illness and caring can all make hours look even while sleep or energy is not, and an uneven split agreed on purpose can be the fair one (see Different hours,

spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours, and When one of you is sick, spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill).

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

Our room agreement

Kayla and Bea, first-year roommates

Our room agreement

Your name
Kayla

Their name
Bea

Quiet hours
11pm to 7am on weeknights, midnight on Fridays and Saturdays. Headphones after that.

Guests (daytime)
Fine with a quick text first. Not during the other one's study or sleep time.

Overnight guests
Up to 2 nights a week, agreed the day before. A guest doesn't stay in the room when their host isn't there.

Cleaning
Kayla: floor and trash cans, Sunday. Bea: desk area and the fridge, Wednesday. Our own laundry, our own job.

Borrowing
Ask first, every time. Food on the shared shelf is for both of us.

Lights and alarms
Big light off by 11:30 on weeknights; a desk lamp is fine. One alarm, one snooze at most.

How we bring up problems
Text first if that's easier, then talk within a few days, one topic at a time. If we're stuck, we ask our RA to help.

YOUR AGREEMENT, READY TO SEND

Our room agreement (Kayla and Bea), with every line above, ending: “We’ll look at it again together in a month.”

They kept most of the site’s starting point and changed two lines.

Fill in your own: Our room agreement

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Different hours
spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours

ONLINE
When one of you is sick
spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill

ONLINE
Our room agreement
spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

Redoing a job someone else already did

FROM OUTSIDE One person loads the dishwasher. The other quietly reloads it.

THE LOGIC Things have a system for a reason. Something in the "wrong" place means hunting for it later. Putting it back saves hassle tomorrow. So it is about the system more than the effort.

IT'S LIKE Library books shelved by number.

WHY IT FITS People who rely on a system feel the cost of a broken one more strongly.

THE OTHER SIDE The person who did the job feels criticized, and may stop helping.

YOU COULD SAY *"Thank you for doing it. I moved a few things for my own system, and you didn't do it badly."*

ONE SMALL STEP Agree which jobs need a set way, write it down, and say thanks first.

BOTH DIRECTIONS Some people care most that a job got done. Others care how it was done, because things have a system and a cup in the "wrong" place means hunting for it later. If you care that it's done, a quiet reload of the dishwasher can feel like your work was graded. If you care about the system, saying the reason ("The bowls go at the back so the door shuts") turns a silent redo into a plan you can share.

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET Politics would say a home is a small government, and a rule lasts when the people who live by it helped make it. That is why the score is filled in together, from both people's own notes. The roots are ownership and structure, and quiet incentives.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=redo-job

Common mix-ups

A low number doesn't mean the relationship is failing. It means the current setup needs changing, and setups change all the time. Please don't guess the numbers. A guessed number is a feeling with a decimal point, so use your written logs. One of you can't fill it out

for both, either. Each person writes their own log and scores their own stress tank. And fair doesn't have to mean exactly 50/50. Fair is what you both agree to with your eyes open, and an uneven split you chose together can be the fair one. Two kinds of fair (Chapter 4, page 73) looks at this.

Small children and a new baby

Small children bring a flood of new jobs, and most of them are thinking jobs, from the daycare bag and the shots to the party invitations, the next size of clothes and the nights. That's why the mental load (see the work nobody sees, Chapter 1, page 18) often grows after a baby arrives, usually without anyone deciding it. Log the children's jobs too, with the thinking time, and count the nights. Hand over whole jobs, like clothes and sizes or the doctor and the shots, so the new owner does the noticing too, in their own way. If a baby is on the way, write your first job list together before the birth, plan the nights, and agree to look again at six weeks, at three months and before either of you goes back to work. In the first weeks, share by energy more than by hours, so whoever was up in the night gets the rest.

Hollie and Gareth have Alfie, who is three, and Poppy, who is eight months, and Gareth is a paramedic on shifts. Their logged minutes came out nearly even, yet Hollie did almost three-quarters of the jobs nobody asked for. They left the minutes alone and moved one whole job, the children's clothes, to Gareth. In the first two weeks Alfie went to daycare in a vest in October. Hollie said nothing, heroically.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "Could you own the daycare bag from now on, including noticing when we're low on diapers? I won't check it."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

Who did what, with small children

Hollie and Gareth, parents of a toddler and a baby; Gareth works shifts

Who did what

Person A
Hollie

Person B
Gareth

Week beginning
October 12, 2026

Part A: Who did what, this week

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Mon	*Pack the daycare bag: spare clothes, diapers, named milk*	*Hollie*	10	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Book Poppy's one-year shots at the doctor*	*Hollie*	15	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Bath and bedtime, both children*	*Gareth*	45	*Asked for*
Wed	*Reply to a party invite and buy the present*	*Hollie*	25	*Noticed and handled*
Wed	*Sort outgrown clothes and order the next size*	*Hollie*	40	*Noticed and handled*
Thu	*Plan the week's meals around Gareth's nights*	*Hollie*	20	*Thinking and planning*

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Thu	*Cook dinner and batch-cook for the weekend*	*Gareth*	75	*Noticed and handled*
Fri	*Remember the daycare photo money and form*	*Hollie*	10	*Thinking and planning*
Fri	*Night wakings with Poppy*	*Hollie*	60	*Noticed and handled*
Sat	*Swimming lesson with Alfie*	*Gareth*	60	*Asked for*
Sat	*Big food shop and diapers*	*Both*	80	*Asked for*
Sun	*Laundry for both children, to put away*	*Hollie*	50	*Noticed and handled*
Sun	*Fix the stair gate*	*Gareth*	20	*Noticed and handled*
Sun	*Update the family calendar and the childcare schedule*	*Hollie*	20	*Thinking and planning*

THIS WEEK'S TOTALS

Hollie
290 minutes (55%), of which 250 noticed and handled without being asked (50 of them thinking and planning)

Gareth
240 minutes (45%), of which 95 noticed and handled without being asked

Workload balance score
0.91. It describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it.

Unasked-for work
Hollie did 72% of the work that was noticed and handled without anyone asking. This is the work that is easiest to miss. Say it out loud, and give the jobs that repeat a named owner.

Part B (optional): Kind ways to say no

Left blank this week.

Gareth worked three night shifts this week, so his rows are fewer; the minutes are close, and the noticing is the part to talk about.

Fill in your own: Who did what

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-01 · free to print
Who did what
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01

If only one of you wants to try this

That's common, and you can still start. Log your own week, score your own tank, and then share one small thing you noticed, without asking the other person to agree with your numbers. A dad noticed he was spending five hours a week driving his sixteen-year-old to training and back. He said so, without any accusation in it, and they agreed on a bus pass for two days a week. His son grumbled for two weeks and then started to enjoy the bus, where nobody asked him how training went. Share one finding at a time, then let it rest for a few days.

If the other person refuses to talk about the split at all, ever, that isn't a setup problem, and no score will fix it.

More for your situation

Money together · Gaming and time together · Friends · Family rifts · Grown-up children · Grandparents · Co-parenting · Coming home · Empty nest · At work · For counselors

To run the check, each of you first logs one week in Who did what, because the number only means something if you each wrote your own. Next, fill out the job list in One owner per job together, including any jobs nobody owns yet, and each score your own stress tank on the same day. Put the three numbers into the calculator, or work it out on paper with "How the numbers work" at the back of this book (page 136). Look first at the biggest shortfall, pick one small change together and check again in a month.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Money together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together

ONLINE
Gaming and time together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together

ONLINE
Friends
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends

ONLINE
Family rifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts

ONLINE
Grown-up children
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children

ONLINE
Grandparents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents

TOOL
Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting

ONLINE
Coming home
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home

ONLINE
Empty nest
spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest

TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

ONLINE
For counselors
spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors

TOOL
Fair split check: this week
spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Look at the month, not last night**, using what you both wrote down.
- ✓ **Three things go in**, which are how the hours split, whether each job has a name, and how full each person's stress tank is.
- ✓ **One number comes out, from 0 to 1.** Start with whichever part pulled it down most.
- ✓ **It judges the setup, never a person**, and it is where a talk starts.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 1 · The work nobody sees
The unseen work the check counts — page 7

Chapter 3 · Full tanks and different angles
The stress input, explained — page 51

Book 2, Chapter 6 · Habits and change
Fixing the setup with small, kind changes — Heal and Steady, page 101

Book 3, Chapter 7 · Helping others well
When one person carries the care — Understanding Each Other, page 113

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 2: give every job one owner
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

One owner per job
Workpaper · free to print
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2-in-depth

3

BOOK 4 · CHAPTER 3

Full tanks and different angles: stress and perspective

Why some reactions are bigger than what caused them, and why two people can see the same moment so differently.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. A full tank overflows
2. Some stress is left over from earlier
3. Check your stress tank in a minute
4. Three everyday states
5. There are seven angles on the same moment
6. Both views can be true
7. Say it instead of making each other guess
8. A full tank means "later," not "never."
9. Words this chapter uses
10. On your own: reading your own tank
11. Common mix-ups
12. Two homes: co-parenting after a split
13. If only one of you wants to try this
14. More for your situation

AT A GLANCE

- **A full tank overflows**, so stress left over from earlier makes small things feel big.
- **Check your tank in a minute**, and say the band out loud so nobody has to guess.
- **Two people can see one moment from different angles**, and both views can be true.
- **A full tank means later**, so pause, name a time and come back.

THURSDAY, 5:15PM

"Did you remember to call the dentist?"

A perfectly pleasant question. What comes out of you in reply is about four sizes too big for it, with a bit about the car thrown in for good measure, and you can hear it happening while it happens, like watching yourself trip on a stair.

Eight in the morning after a night shift, quickly. On the surface, a question about the meter. Underneath, twelve hours on your feet. Underneath that, two people seeing one moment from different angles. The roots are state and setting, and signal and noise. The chapter slows down on the tank, then the angles.

01

A full tank overflows.

If you're already tired or stretched from somewhere else, a small question can get a big reaction, which is simply human. Anything decided in that moment is worth coming back to once you've both calmed down.

Stress from outside leaks in
Daily diaries from newlywed couples showed that spouses under more stress outside the relationship reacted more strongly to everyday irritations inside it. Marnie's morning is a fair example.

Neff and Karney (2009) · *Moderate: daily-diary studies of newlyweds; correlational*

It's eight in the morning and Marnie has just done a twelve-hour night shift and is standing in the kitchen in her coat. Her roommate, eating cornflakes, asks if she saw his message about the electricity meter. She bites his head off, properly, though really it was twelve hours on her feet that did the biting. The meter just happened to be standing at the end of them. She apologized at four in the afternoon, when she woke up, via a note under his door. The

note said, “Sorry. That was bigger than the question. I’m running on empty.”

02

Some stress is left over from earlier.

Ask yourself how much of this feeling is about the thing in front of you and how much you carried in with you. Being upset about the dishes and being exhausted, with the dishes as the thing you happened to notice, are different problems. Some of what we bring in is much older, like an understanding from growing up that whoever notices the mess has to clean it. If a feeling seems a lot older than the moment, Where your lens came from helps you find where it started.

Corey is fourteen and has had a horrible day at school, the sort he won’t talk about. He comes home and finds his brother has taken the phone charger, again. The explosion that follows can be heard two doors down. The charger was the last drop in a tank that had been full since lunchtime.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> “I think I brought this in with me. Give me ten minutes.”

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Old rules, new choices
spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

03

Check your stress tank in a minute.

How much are you carrying? measures how full your stress tank is, and a higher score means more stress in the tank. Score five things from 0 to 4, which are sleep, work elsewhere, any unsettled argument, how your body feels and time pressure today, then add them up and divide by 20. Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 up to 0.60 is medium and 0.60 or more is high. If it's been high for a long time it can start to feel normal, so a quick reading each week is worth it.

Vince has been looking after his wife since her hip operation. He scored 0.65 three days running. That told him something he hadn't let himself think, which was that he needed help more than he needed to try harder. He sat with it for an evening, in the chair by the window with the radio on low. Then he called his son, who said, "Dad, I've been waiting for you to ask since March."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

How much are you carrying?
Rosa, who shares her mom's care with her brother

How much are you carrying?

Fill this out on your own, about yourself only. Never fill it out for someone else.

Your name
Rosa

Date
October 7, 2026

The checklist

0 = Not at all · 4 = Very true

Sleep debt (less rested than usual)

0 1 2 (3) 4

Workload elsewhere (job, school, caregiving)

0 1 2 3 (4)

Recent unresolved conflict (any source)

0 (1) 2 3 4

Physical state (hungry, sick, in pain)

0 1 (2) 3 4

Time pressure today specifically

0 1 2 (3) 4

YOUR STRESS TANK

Your stress tank today
High (13 out of 20 points)

What to do
Put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour. If you need to settle first, the Calm-Down Kit is made for this.

If it can't wait
If what you're carrying can't wait, like caring for someone who is ill, that's a sign to get more help, not to try harder: ask one person for one specific thing this week, and look into respite care.

Filled most by
sleep debt, workload elsewhere, time pressure today. Conditions, not character.

Stress tank score
0.65 out of 1.00

Optional

☑ Some of what I'm carrying is caring for someone

Anything you want to name before talking
Mom's hospital appointment moved to Thursday, and I'm the one driving.

Higher means a fuller stress tank. Rosa scores only herself; her brother fills in his own.

Fill in your own: How much are you carrying?

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-02 · free to print
How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

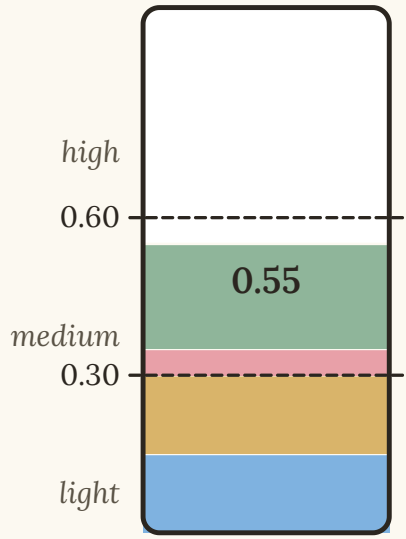
04

Three everyday states.

Knowing whether you're calm and connected, revved up or running on empty tells you whether now is a good time to talk. The Nervous System Ladder, a thirty-second self-check, helps you make a best guess. The labels come from polyvagal theory, whose main claims are still debated by scientists, and here they're used only as everyday words. In one long-distance couple, he takes the video call at midnight his time and is usually running on empty by then, so they've moved the hard talks to Saturday mornings. It helps to know one body clue for each state. A tight jaw is a common one for revved up.

How full is your stress tank?

Score five things from 0 to 4. Add them up, divide by 20.



Sam today

Time pressure today	4
Body: hungry, unwell, in pain	0
Unresolved conflict	1
Workload elsewhere	3
Sleep debt	3
11 ÷ 20	= 0.55

Medium: say it before a hard talk.
"*Heads up, I'm carrying more than usual today.*"

Made-up example from this chapter. The five items and bands are this book's, not a tested questionnaire.

FIGURE 4 How full is your stress tank? Five things scored 0 to 4, added up and divided by 20. The scores shown are an example. The items and bands are this book's.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
My weather today: the sky (the ladder)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

05

There are seven angles on the same moment.

The seven angles are tiredness, time pressure, history, what home was like growing up, your sense of fairness, how you communicate and stress from outside. Many arguments are two people looking from different angles, each sure the other sees what they see. The "See their side" step of Rewind the talk is built on these seven angles and helps you picture how the same moment might look from the other side, with questions to ask in place of guesses.

Christmas, again, and Sasha sees it from family habit, because they always go to her mom's. There's a stocking with each child's name on it, stitched in 2016, and her mom would be heartbroken. Kemi sees it from fairness: they went to her mom's last year, and the year before, and, now that he counts, the year before that.

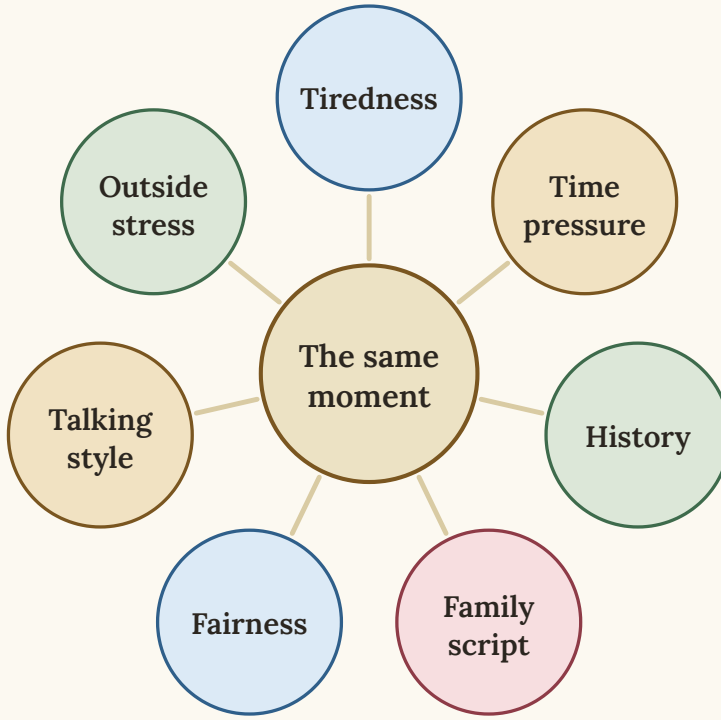
Naive realism

Lee Ross and Andrew Ward described the quiet assumption that we see things as they really are, so anyone who disagrees must be uninformed or unreasonable. Saying your angle out loud is a small way of admitting you have one.

Ross and Ward (1996) · *Strong: a foundational account whose predictions are well replicated*

Seven angles on the same moment

Which one are you looking from right now?



An angle is a place to stand, not a verdict.
Name your own. Ask about theirs.

Illustration. The seven angles are this book's; the Rewind the talk's "See their side" uses them.

FIGURE 5 Seven angles on the same moment. An angle is a place to stand, not a verdict: name your own, and ask about theirs.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

Rewind the talk: see their side

Hana, about her friend Lou

See their side

1. What happened?

I asked Lou if she was still coming to my birthday dinner, and she just replied "maybe."

2. Who are they to you?

Partner · Family · Roommate · *Friend* · Coworker · Co-parent · My teen or child · Someone else

3. What state might they have been in?

Calm and connected · Revved up · *Running on empty* · I'm not sure

4. What might have been going on around them?

A long or hard day · *Little sleep* · Rushed or late · Money worries · *Caring for someone* · Not feeling their best · A noisy or crowded place · Other people were there · *It was a text or message* · It was late at night

5. How are they wired?

They notice tone a lot · They take words literally · *They need time to process* · They think out loud · They're very direct · They hint rather than say · They like a plan · Noise, light or crowds get to them · Their language or culture differs

6. What history might they carry?

This has come up before · They grew up with it done differently · *It's a sore topic for them* · They may feel it's unfair

7. What could each of you see? They may have seen or known things you didn't

their whole day and workload | *a message, call or news you didn't see* | something they had already planned or done | how it looked from where they stood | a promise someone else made them | how they were feeling inside

You may have seen or known things they didn't

the planning you had already done | *the reason behind your timing* | what you actually meant | how tired or stretched you were | the part already done | a deadline only you knew about

Neither of you could fully see

each other's tone, in writing | what was going on in the other's head | what would happen next | what other people had said to each of you

THROUGH THEIR EYES

Running on empty: If they were running on empty, short replies and slow answers are what a tired body does. It can look like not caring when it's only having nothing left.

Caring for someone: Caring for someone else uses up attention you can't see. They may have had less to give than usual.

Questions to check, instead of guessing: "How was your day, before this came up?" "Would it help to think about it and come back to it later?"

A sentence to bridge the gap: "I think we may have been seeing this from different places. On my side, I knew about the reason behind my timing, and I'm not sure that came across. I'm wondering whether you were running on empty. Could we compare notes? I'd like to understand how it looked to you."

These are possibilities to check, not facts about Lou.

Fill in your own: Rewind the talk: see their side

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Rewind the talk
spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

06

Both views can be true.

You can each be right about what you see and still be looking at different parts of the same thing, so the useful question is which angle each of you is seeing it from. Two brothers argued for a year about their late mom's house. One saw thirty years of memories. Height marks on the kitchen door frame, the apple tree, the step where she sat to take her shoes off. The other saw a roof that needed $12,000 of work. Both of them were looking at the real house. In the end they sold it, and the one who saw the memories took the door frame with the height marks on it, which is now leaning against a wall in his garage.

WORDS TO TRY

"You're right about what you see. Can I tell you what I see?"

07

Say it instead of making each other guess.

Before a hard conversation, each of you says how full your tank is and which angle you're seeing from, ideally right at the start.

Two colleagues had a meeting about a missed deadline that both were dreading. One of them, feeling foolish, began with, "Before

we start, I'm about half full today and I'm mostly seeing this from the time angle." After a pause the other said, "Right. I'm pretty full. Fairness angle, if I'm honest." It felt very odd, like reading out your own weather forecast. The meeting was shorter and calmer than the last one, and nobody cried in the restroom afterward, which last time somebody had.



TIDBIT

Say your number out loud. "I'm running high today." Two seconds, and nobody has to guess.

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
My weather today
spreadloveandacceptance.
com/quick-checks

08

A full tank means "later," not "never."

A high score is a reason to pause and never a way out of the talk. Say when you'll come back, and let the Calm-Down Kit help in the meantime. After your calming steps, check your tank again. Under 0.50, go back at the time you said. From 0.50 to 0.59, take another round if you still feel hot, and if you are still at 0.60 or more after two rounds, pick a new time and say when.

It's about phone time, and a dad and his fourteen-year-old are both shouting. "I'm too wound up," he says, "I'll talk to you at seven." She slams her door, and at seven he knocks. It matters more than anything he says once he's inside. That isn't much, or very good, and it is a lot better than not knocking.

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

Flooding
John Gottman's long-term studies of couples gave a name to the point where someone is so physically overwhelmed in a conflict that listening and thinking become very hard. A full tank means later partly because a flooded person can't really do now.

Gottman (1994) · *Moderate: large observational studies; some specific predictions are debated*

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. Your stress tank is the only one you can empty. You can't calm someone else's tank for them, and pouring yours into theirs leaves two empty tanks. Protect yours: rest, say "later," and give energy where it's met. When both tanks are full, the kindest thing you control is the timing. More in Your wiring, weather and words (Book 1, Chapter 2, page 25)

MONDAY MORNING

The mail, eleven envelopes and a pizza menu, on the kitchen table, where they have been since Thursday. One of you sees a to-do list. The other sees proof that nobody in this house ever opens the mail except them. You try saying your angles out loud, like the book says, and it helps for about a minute. Then the gas bill comes up.

The pile is still there at lunchtime.

Words this chapter uses

Your **stress tank** is how much stress you're already carrying before this moment even starts. **Leftover stress** is the part of a feeling you brought in from somewhere else, like poor sleep or a hard day, while **this-moment stress** is caused by what is in front of you right now. An **angle** is the point of view you're seeing a moment from, such as tiredness or fairness.

On your own: reading your own tank

On your own, the most useful habit is a one-minute reading of your tank before you react. Check it for a few mornings in a row and look for a pattern. Ask yourself before a hard moment how much of it is left over from earlier. Decide on a calm day what settles you, so it's ready when you need it. Living alone after a breakup, Beth noticed she snapped at her sister on the phone every single Monday. Her morning readings showed why. Sunday night was her worst sleep of the week, every week, without fail. Now she asks for Tuesday instead, and her sister has stopped asking what's wrong (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

Canceling plans after a long week

FROM OUTSIDE Friday afternoon. “So sorry, I can’t make tonight.”

THE LOGIC Energy comes back with rest. This week spent all of it. Going out on empty means being there in body only. Canceling spares everyone a dull, tired evening.

IT’S LIKE Not driving when you’re too tired to drive safely.

WHY IT FITS A full stress tank changes what anyone has to give.

THE OTHER SIDE The friend may have cleared their evening and been looking forward to it.

YOU COULD SAY *“I’m empty, not uninterested. Can we pick a new day now?”*

ONE SMALL STEP Cancel early, offer a new date in the same message, and plan lighter evenings when the weeks run full.

BOTH DIRECTIONS Some people can say “I’m running high today” easily. Others only realize how full they were once they’ve snapped. If you can name it, the other person may genuinely not know their own number yet. Give them time. If you can’t, the one who names it isn’t making excuses in advance. They’re giving you a weather report so you can plan around it.

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET Neurobiology says your state sets the volume. Psychology adds that mood filters what we hear, and aromatherapy, read modestly, that the setting matters, a quieter room or a later hour. The evidence for particular oils is weak. The room and the timing are what help.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=cancel-tired

Common mix-ups

A big reaction sometimes means it was a big deal. Quite often it means the tank was already full. A high score is never an excuse, either. It’s a note to come back later, never a pass to skip the talk. You can’t tell how full someone else’s tank is, however well you

know them, which is why each person scores only themselves. And a pause isn't the silent treatment. The silent treatment is ignoring someone for days, again and again, to punish them, with no time to come back. A pause has a time to come back, which is why you always say when: "I need twenty minutes. Can we pick this up at eight?" If a pause of yours is being read as the other kind, describe it out loud rather than defending yourself.

Sometimes a reaction is far bigger than the moment, and part of it may belong to something older, from childhood or a past relationship or a frightening time. You can't know someone's history from outside, and guessing out loud ("This is about your ex") rarely helps. Having lived through hard things is never the person's fault, and nothing here is for diagnosing anyone. What you can change is your own half. Slow your pace, lower your voice, sit down, keep the doorway clear and use fewer words. If it's still climbing, say when you'll come back, step away, and then come back when you said you would. The same list works when the big reaction is yours.

Two homes: co-parenting after a split

Children carry two homes, and changeover day fills their tank. Being quiet, extra close or cross for a few hours after a handover is common and usually says nothing bad about the other home. Give them landing time, with a snack and something familiar and no questions about the other home for the first hour. The child is never the messenger. Adult news goes adult to adult. For money, follow any formal arrangement. Split the extras by a ratio you agree, and settle up once a month from one list. With an ex, share the band and keep the story, as in "I'm in a heavy week. Could we swap Wednesday?" and your private life stays yours. If an ex won't cooperate, parallel parenting can work, with written

messages only, short and business-like, handovers at school and your own list for your own home. When there are new partners, the parent stays the owner of anything involving the other home, and a step-parent starts as a friendly adult rather than the one who scolds the children.

Harriet gives Freya, who is eight, and Arlo, who is five, an hour of toast and blankets when they come back from their dad's, and she has stopped asking "How was it?" at the front door. Sunday evenings are calmer. Arlo still cries at bedtime on changeover days, and she's waiting to see whether that eases. Some weeks she thinks it is. Some weeks she isn't sure.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE (A BUSINESS-LIKE MESSAGE)
> "Hi Dylan. Freya's school trip is on November 6 and costs $30. I've paid it and put it on the extras list. Thanks, Harriet."

If only one of you wants to try this

You can do all of this from your own side. Check your own tank, name your own angle, pause and come back on time. The other person doesn't have to use the words for it to help, and when one person starts saying it out loud, the other quite often follows. Lauren visits her dad every Sunday, and every week they clash about his health. She started opening each visit with, "I'm a bit tired today, so if I go quiet it isn't you." He never scored anything himself. He thinks the whole idea is daft. Still, the visits got calmer, and one Sunday in November he said, unprompted, while filling the kettle, "I'm a bit tired today too, sweetheart."

A full tank explains a reaction, and the reaction still needs a repair. "I was running on empty" is a real reason the first time. It stops working as a reason when it closes the conversation every

time and nothing about the week changes. Ask yourself whether you're using the tank to start a conversation or to end one.

More for your situation

Friends · Grown-up children · Family rifts · Co-parenting · Coming home · When one of you is sick · Long distance · Sharing a room · Gaming and time together · For counselors

Before your next hard conversation, score the five things in How much are you carrying?, add them up and divide by 20, then say one sentence out loud about your tank and your angle. If either of you scores 0.60 or more, put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour, and agree on a time to come back.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Friends
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends



ONLINE
Grown-up children
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children



ONLINE
Family rifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts



TOOL
Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting



ONLINE
Coming home
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home



ONLINE
When one of you is sick
spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill



ONLINE
Long distance
spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance



TOOL
Plan it once: room agreement for roommates
spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room



ONLINE
Gaming and time together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together



ONLINE
For counselors
spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors



WORKPAPER WP-02 · free to print
How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 2, Chapter 1 · Stress and the nervous system
The ladder, flooding and rest
Heal and Steady, page 7

Book 3, Chapter 3 · How we see each other
The angles and stories behind a reaction
Understanding Each Other, page 45

Book 2, Chapter 2 · Anger
What to do in the hot minutes
Heal and Steady, page 27

Book 1, Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words
Checking your own weather first
Know Yourself Kindly, page 25

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 3: notice how much each of you is carrying

spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

How much are you carrying?

Workpaper · free to print

spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3-in-depth

4

BOOK 4 · CHAPTER 4

Two kinds of fair: equal vs fair at home

Agree on what "fair" means before you argue about it, and give a comment a moment to land before you answer it.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. There are two kinds of fair
2. Fair by results
3. Fair by promises
4. Once a job has an owner, look to the owner
5. Covering is kind. Say it out loud
6. Let a comment land before you react
7. Notice, name, decide
8. Keep the two questions apart
9. On your own: your own kind of fair
10. Common mix-ups
11. Money between you
12. A couple and a roommate
13. More for your situation
14. A shared agreement, or controlling rules?

THE SAME ARGUMENT, TWICE A MONTH

One of you counts hours. The other counts who noticed the job needed doing in the first place. You are both counting honestly, in two different currencies, then arguing about the exchange rate. This usually happens on a Sunday evening and usually, for reasons nobody can explain, about the oven.

A Sunday-evening row about the oven, seen quickly. The surface is the oven. Underneath, two currencies, hours and noticing. Underneath that, two kinds of fair nobody has named. The roots

are balance and signal and noise. Slowly now, one kind of fair at a time.

01

There are two kinds of fair.

One kind asks whether everything got done. The other asks whether each person did what they said they would. Both are reasonable, and friction starts when each of you is using a different one without realizing.

Nisha and Kezia share a room in the dorms. Nisha thinks a week was fair if the room is tidy by Friday, whoever tidied it. Kezia thinks it was fair if each of them kept her own half clean. For most of the first semester each thought the other was being unreasonable and said so to other people. Neither of them was. It came out at two in the morning over a shared packet of noodles, and they both laughed until the girl next door banged on the wall.

More than one kind of fair

Morton Deutsch argued that equity (you get out what you put in) is only one fairness rule, alongside equality (the same for everyone) and need, and that people lean on different ones in different settings. Research broadly agrees that the setting decides.

Deutsch (1975) · *Moderate: an influential theory, broadly supported*

YOU COULD SAY

"When you say fair, do you mean it all gets done, or that we each do our bit?"

Two kinds of fair

Both are reasonable. Trouble starts when you use different ones without saying so.

Fair by results

Asks: Did it all get done?

Guards: Will the home keep running?

Good: flexible. Watch: it can hide who always steps in.

- Trash ✓
- Dentist ✓
- Forms ✓

Fair by promises

Asks: Did each of us do what we agreed?

Guards: Can I rely on you?

Good: clear. Watch: it can feel rigid in a hard week.

- Trash · Sam ✓
- Dentist · Maya ✗
- Forms · Lin ✓

The agreement: look to the owner

Trash · owner: Sam

second name: Alex, who notices and asks once

Once a job has a named owner, judge it by whether the owner did their part (swapping or asking ahead counts), not by whether someone quietly covered. Made-up examples.

FIGURE 6 Two kinds of fair. Both are reasonable. Trouble starts when people use different ones without saying so. Once a job has an owner, look to the owner.

02

Fair by results.

This kind of fair judges by outcomes, by whether the right things got done by whoever had the time or energy. It's flexible and easy-going, which is lovely when it works. Done carefully it counts the cost to whoever covered. Done carelessly it hides who is always stepping in.

Marjorie is raising her grandchildren. Her grown-up son helps with whatever's needed when he's home, cheerfully and well. The house runs, and she is always, always the one who notices what's needed. She didn't see it herself until she marked, for one week, every job she picked up that wasn't planned. It came to forty-one, and she showed her son. He said, "Forty-*one*?" and then, after a bit, "Right."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 8

Who does what? The Money tab

Grace and Ruth, a couple with different incomes

Money (optional)

One line per cost. Put what each person actually paid.

Currency
$ (dollars)

Bill	Grace paid ($)	Ruth paid ($)	How it's shared
Rent	1,100	700	*Shared, split*
Power and water	160	0	*Shared, split*
Internet and phones	0	90	*Shared, split*
Groceries	300	250	*Shared, split*

	Grace brings in ($)	Ruth brings in ($)	How it's shared

	Grace brings in ($)	Ruth brings in ($)	How it's shared
Pay	*4,200*	*2,800*	*Money coming in*

THE SUMMARY

Each person's total: Grace $1,560; Ruth $1,040.

Coming in: $7,000 (Grace $4,200, Ruth $2,800). After shared bills: $4,400 left.

Two ways to split the shared bills. Split evenly: Ruth would put in $260 more · Split by income (60/40): it already comes out even. Pick whichever feels fair to you.

Even isn't always the fair answer (incomes and rooms differ), so treat this as a starting point, not a verdict.

Fill in your own: Who does what? (Money tab)

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL

Who does what? Count the hours and bills

spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand

03

Fair by promises.

This kind asks whether each person did the jobs they agreed to own. It's clear and steady, and it can feel rigid in a week when life gets in the way. Two business partners run a café. One owns the ordering, the other owns the staff schedule. When the schedule is late (it's the Thursday before a long weekend, it is always late then) they ask the schedule owner about it, not "the team." And nobody takes it personally, or not for long.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"It's my job, and I can't do it this week. Could you take it, and I'll take out the trash?"

04

Once a job has an owner, look to the owner.

The owner is the person who does the job from start to finish. A second name on the list is a backstop, who notices if it slipped and checks in gently without supervising, and it can be the same person. If the job is yours, the question is whether you did it, and somebody quietly covering for you doesn't answer that. It also protects the person who keeps filling the gaps.

In one stepfamily, Ethan, who is thirteen, owns feeding the dog. His stepmum Claire is the second name. When the bowl is empty at seven and the dog is staring at it with enormous meaning, Claire says "Dog's dinner?" once, just that. She doesn't do it for him and she doesn't lecture. For the first month this nearly killed her. Ethan now feeds the dog most nights before anyone mentions it, and the dog has stopped staring at Claire.

Opening the gate

In 97 couples with babies, fathers did more of the day-to-day care when mothers actively encouraged them, and when mothers were very critical, fathers' own beliefs about being involved made less difference. It's one US sample, but Claire's single "Dog's dinner?" is gate-opening in miniature.

Schoppe-Sullivan and colleagues (2008) · *Moderate: an observational study of one US sample; correlational*

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 9

One owner per job

Dee and Mark, foster caregivers

One owner per job: caring for a child in care

Person A
Dee

Person B
Mark

Date of this list
October 4, 2026

The split you agreed (optional)
Dee works three days; Mark works full time

Who owns each job

Job	How often	Roughly how long?	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Social worker visits	*Monthly*	1.5	*Dee*	*Mark*	*Mark joins by video when he can*
Reviews and meetings	*As needed*	2	*Dee*	*Mark*	*Dee books and preps; Mark comes to the big ones*
Daily log and placement paperwork	*Daily*	0.5	*Dee*	*Mark*	*Mark writes it on Dee's work days*
Contact visits and calls with their family	*Weekly*	1.5	*Mark*	*Dee*	*Saturday mornings*
School liaison (designated teacher, plans)	*As needed*	1	*Dee*		

Job	How often	Roughly how long?	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Being there after contact	*As needed*	1	*Mark*	*Dee*	*Quiet tea, no questions*
Health and therapy appointments	*As needed*	1.5	*Dee*		
Training and support group	*Monthly*	2	*Mark*		*Mark's turn this semester*

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

Jobs with an owner
8 of 8. Every job has an owner.

How the jobs are spread
Counted by how often each job comes round, and by size or time where you gave it: Dee 61% · Mark 39%. You wrote down the split you agreed: "Dee works three days; Mark works full time." Does this match it? It's a starting point for a talk, not a scorecard.

☑ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)
Dee and Mark

"Being there after contact" is on the list because hidden work counts.

Fill in your own: One owner per job (caring for a child in care)

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

05

Covering is kind. Say it out loud.

Helping out when the owner can't is lovely, and it helps to mention it, so the help is seen. "I took the trash out this week, since you were away." Help that stays silent turns into unseen work, and unseen help slowly becomes expected (see Complacency, spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency).

Two sisters take turns driving their dad to his appointments. When one covers for the other, she texts the same day. *Took Dad Thurs, you were on late shifts. All fine, blood work normal, he flirted with the receptionist.* It takes ten seconds to send and stops the help going invisible. The second half of the message is, they both agree, the important bit.



SUGARFOOT

Covering for someone is kind. Say that you did, gently, or it turns into the quiet sort of resentment that nobody mentions until Christmas.

TOOL **Small wins: Flip it** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Complacency
spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency

TOOL
Small wins: Flip it
spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

06

Let a comment land before you react.

When a remark hits harder than it should, say "Give me a second." The idea is borrowed loosely from brain science, where the brain turns down sounds and sensations automatically in a fraction of a second, while this pause is a few seconds you choose to take on purpose. Let the spike pass, then decide whether the remark needs an answer now or later, or at all.

Two in the afternoon. Fran has come downstairs after a night shift, hair everywhere. Her husband looks up from the table. "Oh, you're up." She has been asleep for six hours, dreaming about a hospital rounds, and what she hears is *at last*. She's halfway into a reply before she stops and says, "Give me a second, I'm really tired." He looks puzzled, because he'd meant he was glad to see her. He'd saved her the last of the soup (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours). Agree your own "give me a second" phrase today, while things are calm.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Different hours
spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours

07

Notice, name, decide.

First notice that a comment landed hard. Then name it, kindly ("That hit harder than you probably meant"). Once you've settled, decide how to reply. Say it so it lands helps with the words.

"You *never* listen," his fifteen-year-old said, on the stairs. Andy felt his chest go tight, and a speech started assembling itself somewhere behind his teeth. He wanted very much to list the times he had listened. What he said was, "Ouch. That stings. And I do want to hear you properly." Then he decided it needed a real talk, the next evening, after her swimming, in the car, which is where they talk best, both looking at the road.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 10

Say it so it lands

Carla, who runs a café with her business partner Femi

Say it so it lands

Your name
Carla

Date
October 8, 2026

Before you speak or send: fact, feeling, ask

Use it on one thing that actually stung.

Raw reaction
Great, so I'm doing the stock order on my own again.

What's the fact underneath this? (One sentence, no adjectives.)
The stock order for the café wasn't placed by Tuesday noon, and I placed it at 4pm.

What's the feeling underneath this? (Frustrated, tired, unseen, rushed…)
I felt stretched thin, and a bit alone with it.

What's the actual ask? (What do you want to happen next, specifically?)
Could you own the Tuesday stock order from next week, with me as backup when you're at the bank?

Before you react: four quick checks

Is this about a specific, nameable task or event?

(*Yes*) No

Would I read this the same way if I weren't already carrying a lot?

Yes No (*Not sure*)

Is there a neutral interpretation that also fits what was said?

(*Yes*) No

Am I responding to their words, or to a pattern from a past conversation?

(*Their words*) A past pattern

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ways to say it
Quick one, no rush: could you own the Tuesday stock order from next week, with me as backup when you're at the bank?

Suggestions
Your own stress tank is part of how this reads. A few hours, or a night's sleep, often changes how it reads. There's a kinder reading that also fits. Try asking about it first: "Did you mean ___, or ___?"

The raw reaction stays on the sheet, not in the message.

Fill in your own: Say it so it lands

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-09 · free to print
Say it so it lands
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09

08

Keep the two questions apart.

Whether the job was done is a question about a fact. Whether the comment hurt is a question about a feeling. Both matter, and each goes better in its own conversation.

Separated parents share their children across two homes. The bag came back on Sunday without the school shoes, and with it a text about the shoes that felt, to the one who received it, very cold. They settled the shoes first, on the phone, in about two minutes. They talked about the text the following Sunday. It took longer and was more awkward, and it was better for waiting a week (see Co-parenting, spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting). When a talk tangles, “Fact or feeling?” is a good question to ask out loud. Finish one before you start the other.

Let a comment land

Timing, not hiding: let the spike pass before you decide.

1. **Notice**
   It landed harder than its words. Hot face, tight chest, a sharp breath.
2. **Name it out loud**
   "I heard that as bigger than it probably was. Give me a second."
3. **Decide, once settled**
   Reply now, later, or not at all. Could a kinder meaning fit?

Keep the two questions apart

"Was this job done?"	"Did that land as an attack?"
A fact.	**A reaction.**
Check the job list and its owner.	Check your own state first.

Naming a feeling (affect labeling) and looking for another meaning (reappraisal) both have some research behind them.

FIGURE 7 Let a comment land before you react: notice, name, decide. And keep the fact question apart from the feeling question.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You control whether, when and how you bring something up, and whether you cover a job out loud. How the other person responds is theirs. If you cover again and again with no thanks and no change, match the energy: cover less, and say so kindly. Fair by promises only works when both people keep theirs. More in Your wiring, weather and words (Book 1, Chapter 2, page 25)

THE WEEKLY CATCH-UP

Sam and Alex share a home. Alex owns the trash but works late on Tuesdays, and Sam has quietly taken them out three weeks running. At the catch-up Sam mentions it, not very smoothly. Alex goes a bit red and admits that Tuesday nights aren't realistic with the late shifts. They agree to try a swap for the rest of the month, with Sam taking out the trash and Alex taking the recycling and the weekly grocery order, and to settle it at the monthly look-back in Chapter 5 (page 97).

WEDNESDAY, 7PM

"Thanks for doing the dishes," one of you says, a little deflated. It was meant as a thank-you, and it came out sounding like a criticism. Before you know it you've answered the criticism, the person who said thank you is defending a thank-you, and the dishes are still in the rack.

On your own: your own kind of fair

Fair starts with knowing what it means to you, and which jobs are truly yours. Write down what fair means to you in one sentence, and list the jobs you own alongside the ones you picked up without ever agreeing to. Errol lives alone and has his children every other weekend. His sentence, after a lot of crossing out, is that fair means not doing their jobs for them just because he misses them (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). He finds this very hard on Sunday afternoons, when he'd happily do everything if it meant another hour. Pick one job you took on without agreeing, and either keep it on purpose or raise it on a calm day.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

Different ideas of “on time”

FROM OUTSIDE One person is ready at seven sharp. The other thinks seven means “from seven.”

THE LOGIC “Seven o’clock” is read through a rule learned at home. In some families it means exactly seven, in others roughly seven. Each person turns up when their own rule says is polite. Neither is careless. They read the same words differently.

IT’S LIKE A recipe that says “a pinch.”

WHY IT FITS Families, workplaces and kinds of event all keep time differently.

THE OTHER SIDE Whoever waits may feel unimportant, and the dinner goes cold.

YOU COULD SAY *“Where I grew up, seven meant from seven.”*

ONE SMALL STEP Say which kind of time you mean. “Seven sharp, the table’s booked.”

BOTH DIRECTIONS Some people learned at home that seven means seven sharp, and arriving at five after feels like a small slight. Others learned that seven means from seven, and arriving on the dot is a little too eager. If you’re a seven-sharp person, the other person isn’t careless. They’re being polite by their own rule. If you’re a from-seven person, saying “Is that seven sharp?” costs nothing and saves the wait.

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET Philosophy asks you to agree which kind of fair you’re using before you argue about it. The art of debating adds: say their strongest point first. And music explains why “Thanks for doing the dishes” can still go wrong, because tone carries more than the words.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
`spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=on-time-means`

Common mix-ups

If it got done, there may still be a problem, because someone may be paying for it in time and energy. Holding the owner to the job isn’t being strict. It’s keeping the agreement you both made, which is kinder than quiet resentment. Letting a comment

land doesn't mean ignoring it. It's about timing, and you still get to answer. And please don't save up months of covering to bring out all at once. A long list lands like a bill, so mention covering as it happens.

Money between you

Money is where the two kinds of fair meet most often. Some couples put everything into one pot. Some keep their money separate and pay agreed bills, often half each, which is fair by promises, the same rule for both. Others each pay into a shared pot in line with what they earn and keep the rest, which is fair by results, since each is left with a similar share. Many couples mix them, with a joint account for bills and food and some money each that nobody has to explain. The right way is the one you both chose with your eyes open. To talk about it, start with your money stories, how money worked at home when you were growing up, then move on to the numbers and to a "talk first" amount for big purchases that applies to both of you.

Niamh takes home $3,300 a month and Tariq $2,400, and their rent and bills will be $1,900. They split it 58/42, in line with their pay, so she pays $1,100 and he pays $800.

Having a say

Procedural justice research, which began with Thibaut and Walker, finds that whether people feel a decision was reached fairly, and above all whether they had a voice in it, shapes how they feel about the result. A good reason to work a split out together rather than hand one over.

Thibaut and Walker (1975) · *Strong: one of the more robust findings in social psychology, though early lab methods were criticized*

WORDS TO TRY

"Can we each say how money worked in our families growing up?" "Would half each, or in line with our pay, feel fairer to you?"

A couple and a roommate

A couple sharing a home with a roommate who isn't a partner is a different shape from three equals. It helps to keep two lists, **house jobs** for all three of you, such as the trash, the bathroom, the bills and the landlord, and **couple jobs** for the two of you. Decide house questions with all three of you there, not in bed the night before. Hear the roommate first on anything that affects them, keep couple arguments out of shared rooms, and never ask them to referee. Ollie and Hamza share an apartment with their friend Bex. They split the rent by room, since the couple has the bigger one, and the bills by person, and all three hold a short house meeting on the first Sunday of the month, with cookies, which Bex insists is the only reason she turns up. Anything that comes up in between gets the stock answer, "That's a house question, let's decide it when Bex is here."

More for your situation

Each of these pages takes the ideas in this chapter into one kind of relationship. Start from your relationship lists them all.

- Friends · More than two partners · Sharing a room · Money together
- Foster and kinship families · When a child has ADHD · Grown-up children · Family rifts
- Different hours · Coming home · When one of you is sick · Two faiths · On my own

On a calm, easy day, each of you can say which kind of fair comes more naturally, results or promises. Then pick three regular jobs and write an owner for each in the job list in One owner per job, with a second name for someone who notices if it slips. Finally, agree a short phrase for when something lands hard (“Give me a second” does fine), along with the promise that whoever asked for a second will come back to it.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Start from your relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

ONLINE
Friends
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends

ONLINE
More than two partners
spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two

TOOL
Plan it once: room agreement for roommates
spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room

ONLINE
Money together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together

ONLINE
Foster and kinship families
spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship

ONLINE
When a child has ADHD
spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids

ONLINE
Grown-up children
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children

ONLINE
Family rifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts

ONLINE
Different hours
spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours

ONLINE
Coming home
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home

ONLINE
When one of you is sick
spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill



ONLINE
Two faiths
spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths



ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own



WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

A shared agreement, or controlling rules?

A promise is something both people chose and either can ask to change. It can still feel strict ("no new subscriptions without a chat first"), and that's fine, because it binds you both. "Controlling" is a serious word, and it gets used for ordinary disagreements far too often.

For something to be controlling, these are usually all present:

- one person sets rules for the other's ordinary life, such as money, friends, time, clothes or phone,
- the rules bind one side and not the other,
- they're enforced by checking or by a penalty nobody agreed to, such as money held back, days of coldness or threats to leave,
- the other person's no isn't accepted, and it has become a pattern rather than one bad week.

Not enough on its own:

- a shared agreement you both chose, even a strict one,
- a partner who likes budgets, plans or detail more than you do,
- asking where you are, or worrying when you're late,
- a limit someone sets on their own behavior ("I won't lend money again"),

- a need for routine or knowing what's coming.

If a rule feels one-sided, name the rule rather than the person. "The talk-first amount seems to apply to my spending and not yours. Can we set one that covers us both?"

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **There are two kinds of fair**, by results (did it all get done?) and by promises (did each of us do what we agreed?), so agree which one you are using.
- ✓ **Once a job has an owner, look to the owner**, and when you cover for someone, say so out loud.
- ✓ **Let a comment land before you react** by noticing it, naming it and then deciding what to say.
- ✓ **Keep the two questions apart**, because whether the job was done is a fact and whether the comment hurt is a feeling.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 2, Chapter 5 · Healing after hurt — Heal and Steady, page 81
Repair and apologies that land

Book 3, Chapter 2 · How communication works — Understanding Each Other, page 23
Letting words land before you reply

Book 2, Chapter 7 · Values, meaning and a good life — Heal and Steady, page 117
Fairness as a value you choose together

Book 3, Chapter 6 · Groups, influence and culture — Understanding Each Other, page 95
How a group's norms decide what feels fair

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 4: talk about it kindly
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

Say it so it lands
Workpaper · free to print
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4-in-depth

5

BOOK 4 · CHAPTER 5

The monthly look-back: a calm relationship check-in

Once a month, look back for the problems that keep coming back, and fix the setup instead of having the same argument again.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Weekly check-ins miss patterns
2. You need four weeks of notes and one list
3. Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped
4. A problem that keeps coming back usually has no real owner
5. Sort each repeat into one of three kinds
6. Count the gaps each month
7. Look back even when nothing is slipping
8. It's not a review of either person
9. Keep it short and kind
10. A look-back, three months in
11. Common mix-ups
12. Starting out: before you move in
13. Raising a grandchild (kinship care)
14. More for your situation
15. On your own: a monthly look at yourself

THE THIRD TUESDAY IN A ROW

The trash again. You could have the same ten-minute back-and-forth you had last Tuesday, word for word. You know your lines and so do they.

Or you could notice that this is the third Tuesday running, and wonder what it is about Tuesdays.

The trash on a third Tuesday, quickly. On the surface, the same short argument. Underneath, a job that keeps slipping.

Underneath that, a job nobody owns. The roots are feedback loops and ownership and structure. Then the chapter slows down and walks through the look-back.

01

Weekly check-ins miss patterns.

Four roommates had an overflowing bathroom trash can every week, and every week it seemed like bad luck, until they looked at the month together and saw it had happened every single week since September. One missed job looks like bad luck. The same job missed week after week is a pattern, and patterns are easiest to see when you look at a whole month at once.

Latent conditions

James Reason, writing about accidents in organizations, showed how they grow out of latent conditions, gaps that sit quietly in a system until they meet an ordinary slip on an ordinary day. A job with no owner is a latent condition.

Reason (1997) · *Strong: foundational in safety science*

In my old job the step that got skipped more than any other was going back afterward to check that the fix had actually held, and skipping it is exactly how the same problem turns up again three years later. This chapter is that step, made small. A careful, friendly glance over the month, closer to a self-check than an inspection. Choose a monthly date now, the last Sunday, say, and put it in everyone's calendar.

02

You need four weeks of notes and one list.

Bring the month's four weekly notes from Who did what, where a few lines a week is enough, and your job list from One owner per job. Twenty minutes is usually plenty. If either of your stress tanks is high that day, at 0.60 or more on How much are you carrying?, move it a day or two.

Kat and Nathan work different shifts and keep their weekly notes in one shared note on their phones, mostly typed at red lights. They do the look-back on the one evening a month they're both off, with takeout from the Nepalese place. It has become, slightly to their embarrassment, the evening of the month they look forward to most.

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-01 · free to print
Who did what
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01



WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03



WORKPAPER WP-02 · free to print
How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

03

Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped.

A job slipped if it was noticed and not done, only done after being raised more than once, or quietly covered by someone who isn't its owner. Look closely at every job with two or more ✗, because three or four in a month is a real pattern.

Two foster caregivers found the reading log had been missed three weeks out of four. Both of them had an explanation ready. They marked the ✗ in pencil first, together, before either of them said anything at all, which is much harder than it sounds and much the best order. Then the explanations, which turned out to be the same one.

04

A problem that keeps coming back usually has no real owner.

That kind of problem gets patched every week and never fixed. The owner is the person who does the job from start to finish, so the fix is to give the job one owner whose name sticks, or to talk honestly about whether anyone has the time and energy for it.

In a house with three partners, "whoever's free" did the online grocery order. It was late three times this month, once by a whole day. With nobody owning it, everybody assumed someone else had it in hand. One Friday there was no milk at all in the house, and four jars of mustard.

Diffusion of responsibility

In a famous experiment, people who thought others could also hear someone having a seizure were slower to help, and less likely to, because each felt less responsible. A grocery order is a long way from an emergency, but "whoever's free" runs on the same arithmetic.

Darley and Latané (1968) · *Strong: classic and widely replicated, though weaker in clearly dangerous emergencies*

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 11

One owner per job: a list for two homes

Laura and Dan, co-parents in two homes

One owner per job: a list for two homes

Person A
Laura

Person B
Dan

Date of this list
October 1, 2026

The split you agreed (optional)
Week on, week off; handoff Sunday at 5

Who owns each job

Job	How often	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Pack the handoff bag	*Weekly*	*Laura*	*Dan*	*Laura keeps the checklist and the spare kit; whoever hands over packs from it*
Send medicine and chargers with the bag	*Weekly*	*Laura*	*Dan*	*Inhaler: write the last dose time on the card*
School forms and permission slips	*As needed*	*Dan*	*Laura*	
Reply to school emails and apps	*Weekly*	*Dan*		*Dan reads them Sunday night*
Kids' doctor and dentist visits	*As needed*	*Dan*		*Dan books; tells Laura the date*

Job	How often	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Homework help (Laura's weeks)	*Daily*	*Laura*		
Homework help (Dan's weeks)	*Daily*	*Dan*		
Activities and sign-ups	*As needed*	*Dan*	*Laura*	*Swimming and Cub Scouts*
Buy clothes as they outgrow them	*As needed*	*Laura*		*Receipts in the shared folder*
Big decisions (school, health, new activities)	*As needed*	*Both (decide together)*		*A decision, not a job: Dan puts it on the list; talked through by phone, never at handoff*

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

Jobs with an owner
10 of 10. Every job has an owner.

How the jobs sit across the homes
Counted by how often each job comes round (a daily job about five times a weekly one): Laura's home 52% · Dan's home 47% · Together 1%. You wrote down the split you agreed: "Week on, week off; handoff Sunday at 5." Does this match it? Two homes rarely split evenly, and that can be fair: weekdays and weekends, distance and work all play a part.

Fill in your own: One owner per job (two homes)

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

05

Sort each repeat into one of three kinds.

If a job has no clear owner, update the job list. If its owner can't keep up, have a kind, honest talk. If there was a short-term cause, like a bout of flu, note it and move on.

The homework folder kept coming back unsigned. Two separated parents looked at it at the look-back and went through the three kinds, out loud, quite carefully, because last time they'd argued. Was nobody sure which home signs it, was one of them swamped, or was it just the week one of them had the flu? It was the first one. It had been the first one since September (see Co-parenting, spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting).

The monthly look-back

Which gaps kept reopening, however often we closed them?

1 Mark the month

	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4
Recycling	✕	✕	✕	✕
Trash	✕	✕	·	✕
School forms	·	✕	·	·
Dog's walk	·	·	·	·

The ✗ goes next to a job, never next to a person.

2 Sort each repeat

Structural gap
No clear owner, or the wrong name on the list. → **Update the job list.**

Capacity issue
An owner who has run out of room. → **Set a time for a kind talk.**

One-off
A clear short-term reason: illness, travel. → **Note it and move on.**

3 Count, and close the month

Fewer structural gaps over several months is a good sign. Zero isn't the goal.

Short and kind. A look at the setup, not a review of either person.

This book's own method, adapted from team "retrospectives"; it hasn't been tested as a household method.

FIGURE 8 The monthly look-back: mark the month, sort each repeat, count and close. The cross goes next to a job, never a person.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 12

What keeps coming back?

Ash, Robin and Jules, a triad sharing a home

What keeps coming back?

Person A
Ash

Person B
Robin

Person C
Jules

Month
September 2026

Part A: Gather the month's notes

Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped. ✗ = it slipped that week.

Task	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4	Times flagged
Cat litter	✗	✗		✗	3
Recycling out on Thursday		✗	✗		2
Book Jules's car service			✗		1
Shared calendar kept up to date	✗	✗	✗	✗	4

Part B: Sort each gap

Sort every task flagged twice or more.

Task	Named owner on the job list?	Classification	Action
Cat litter	*No*	*Structural gap*	*Robin owns it, with Ash as backup; on the one-owner list tonight*
Shared calendar kept up to date	*Yes*	*Capacity issue*	*Ash owns it but is on nights this month; talk on Sunday about what comes off Ash's list*
Recycling out on Thursday	*Yes*	*One-off, no action*	*The city moved pickup day twice*

PART C: WRAP UP THE AUDIT

Structural gaps found

1. Update One owner per job for each of these in this session.

Capacity issues found

1. Set a time for the conversation. This audit brings it to light, but it doesn't replace it.

One-offs

1

Part D (optional): Thanked, or only noticed when it's missed?

Job	Gets thanked	Only noticed when missed?	One way to notice it
Keeping the calendar	*Rarely*	*Yes*	*Say thanks at Sunday dinner when it's up to date*
Topping up the cat food	*Never*	*Yes*	*A note on the fridge*

A task with no owner is a gap in the setup, not a verdict on the person

who kept covering it.

Fill in your own: What keeps coming back?

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting



WORKPAPER WP-04 · free to print
What keeps coming back?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04

06

Count the gaps each month.

Write down how many gaps of each kind you found. If the number of jobs with no clear owner falls over several months, the setup is working, and a single month can be a normal wobble. If it keeps going up, something bigger has changed and it's worth a talk. Two business partners write their monthly count on a whiteboard in the back office, next to the fire-drill notice. In March four jobs had no clear owner. By June, one did, and they argue quite cheerfully about whose fault that one is.

07

Look back even when nothing is slipping.

A month with no gaps is good news. It's also the month most likely to go unchecked. When something has worked for a while, people stop looking, and nothing breaks on the day that happens. Keep the look-back going in quiet months and add one question, "*What's something we've stopped noticing or mentioning?*," which is how a look-back guards against complacency.

The children have left home and nothing whatsoever is slipping. The look-back takes eleven minutes. At the end Dave says, quietly, looking at his tea, that they don't really talk at dinner any more. Jan had noticed it too, months ago, without knowing how to say it. No list would have shown it.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
complacency
spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency

08

It's not a review of either person.

You don't add up old hours or punish old mistakes. You can thank someone for what they carried before, and you leave the past unbilled. The only question is where the setup isn't working yet and what you'll try next month. After a month in the hospital, Yusuf came home to a long list of what had slipped while he was away. His partner had been dreading showing it to him. He read it, and then he said thank you for the bits that hadn't slipped, which was most of them, and they set up the month ahead. That was all.

A just culture
Sidney Dekker argues for a just culture, one that separates honest mistakes from reckless ones, and points out that who draws that line matters as much as where it's drawn. At home, I'd draw it together, on a calm day.

Dekker (2007) · *Moderate: an influential book; the evidence is mainly case studies*



TIDBIT

Start the look-back with something that went well. It changes the temperature of the whole twenty minutes.

TOOL **Kitchen-table check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Kitchen-table check-in
spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins

09

Keep it short and kind.

Start with something that went well and talk about the job instead of the person. If a gap needs a proper talk, set it for another day using Check-ins. If a talk starts going badly, either of you can call a pause, and whoever paused names a time to come back. A mom and two teenagers hold their look-back over pizza on the last Friday. Each says one good thing first (the younger one's is always "the pizza"). One gap gets a new owner. It's over in fifteen minutes and nobody has stormed off, which in that house is a result.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 13

Kitchen-table check-in: this week

Linda and her grown-up son Jordan, who live together

Our weekly check-in

Week of Oct 5 · Linda and Jordan

Who's checking in (optional)
Linda and Jordan

One thing that went well
Jordan cooked twice, and we ate together on Thursday.

One thing that felt heavy
The bathroom, again. And Mom's back was bad all week.

One small thing to try next week
Jordan owns the bathroom on Saturdays. Linda stops checking it.

Our next check-in
Sunday after dinner

Any jobs that slipped or came up again this week? (optional)

Dishes · Laundry · Trash and recycling · Groceries · Cooking · *Cleaning the bathroom* · Paying the bills · Planning and remembering

ON THE CARD

One topic at a time. We're on the same side. Tick a job once it has one owner.

Fill in your own: Kitchen-table check-in: this week

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. In the look-back you can only fix the gaps you own, and offer help with the rest. You can't make someone keep a rhythm. Keep the rhythms you can keep, notice which ones are kept in return, and let your effort follow: more where it's shared, less where it isn't, so the rhythm doesn't run on one person's energy. More in Your wiring, weather and words (Book 1, Chapter 2, page 25)

THE LAST SUNDAY OF THE MONTH

Two mugs of tea, four weeks of notes and about twenty minutes. You go down the list together, and most weeks were fine. Two jobs keep coming up, the recycling and the call to the landlord about the window that won't shut. You give each of them a name, and the landlord one goes to whoever's least scared of the landlord. You finish your tea while it's still warm, which hasn't happened on a Sunday in months.

A look-back, three months in

Sam and Alex's trash cans slipped three weeks running because Alex works late on Tuesdays. After the trial swap they make it official, so Sam owns the trash and Alex takes the recycling and the weekly grocery order, which keeps the hours even. The second month is clean. In the third, the grocery order slips twice, both times in a week when Alex's mom was in the hospital, so they mark it as a one-off and leave the list alone. What actually changes in month three is that Alex mentions, almost in passing, while stacking the plates, that he has stopped enjoying their Saturday mornings. No list had shown that. They agree to talk about it properly on Thursday, and Sam spends most of the week worrying about it.

YOU COULD SAY

"I don't think anyone dropped this. I think nobody ever picked it up."

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

Needing it in writing

FROM OUTSIDE After a chat about who does what, someone asks, "Could you write that down?"

THE LOGIC Spoken words vanish as they're said. Holding them in mind while doing the job splits attention. Written steps can be checked again. Asking for writing means wanting to get it right.

IT'S LIKE A recipe card, rather than a cook calling instructions from the next room.

WHY IT FITS Working memory differs a lot between people, and writing turns memory into something you can rely on.

THE OTHER SIDE It can sound like distrust of what was agreed.

YOU COULD SAY *"I ask for it in writing so I get it right. I trust what we agreed."*

ONE SMALL STEP End each look-back with a two-line written summary.

BOTH DIRECTIONS Some people remember a spoken plan easily and find a written list a bit formal. Others lose spoken words as they're said, because holding them in mind while doing the job splits their attention. If you remember easily, a request for writing isn't mistrust. It's someone trying to get it right. If you need it written, offering to write it yourself ("I'll send us both a note") keeps it light.

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET Behavioral science says habits beat good intentions, so a look-back works best as a routine too small to skip. Holistic therapies would start with the body, a cup of tea before the list, and some of these practices are well studied while others are debated. A shared laugh, which the research says only modest things about, is still a good way to start.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=written-please

Common mix-ups

This isn't where you settle who owes what. Past hours are never billed to anyone, though you can still say thank you for them. You only fix the setup going forward. A slipped job doesn't mean its owner failed, either, because the gap might be in the list, or in the owner's capacity, or in one strange week. And you can't skip the weekly notes and just do this. The look-back only works if the weekly notes feed it.

A look-back is something you both choose. It looks at the month and the setup, using notes you each kept about your own side. Monitoring is different. It means one person asking for the other's every hour, checking their phone without agreement, or using the ✗ marks as evidence against them. A partner who simply likes detail, or asks "How did the week go?" isn't monitoring. If the look-back starts to feel like being checked up on, pause it and talk about how it's being used before you go on.

Starting out: before you move in

If you are new together and about to share a home, the tools work best now, before habits set, at about one step a week. In the first week, each of you writes down the rulebook from the home you grew up in and then you swap, with curiosity. In the second, talk about money, starting with your money stories and moving on to the split (Chapter 4, page 90). In the third, write your first job list, with one owner per job and the thinking jobs included (One owner per job, spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03), and in the fourth, make a pause plan on a calm day. In the fifth, each name three things that matter most to you about a home (Book 2, Chapter 7, page 117). After the move, log one ordinary week once two weeks have passed, and

do your first short look-back after four. None of it is a test. The point is that neither of you has to guess.

Niamh and Tariq, eight months together, find that their families meant very different things by "tidy." They agree on the kitchen every night and the rest on Sunday, and on Tariq's mother never being told about the rest.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
rulebook from the home you grew up in
spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up



WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03



ONLINE
a pause plan
spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw

Raising a grandchild (kinship care)

Many grandparents and other relatives raise a child whose parents can't, and much of it involves things that keep coming back, such as canceled calls and the hard evenings after contact. A monthly look-back helps. Some repeats you can own. Some, like a parent who misses calls, you can't, and for those you can own the plan for the evening after. The child may love both the parent who can't look after them and you, so tell them they don't have to choose, and don't run the parent down in front of them. Explain an absent parent in a few true words that fit their age, always with the message that it isn't their fault. When the parent is your own grown-up child and things are hard between you, keep messages about the child short and civil for the child's sake, and leave the door open. Look after yourself too. Ask for respite, and find other kinship caregivers.

Maureen, who is sixty-three, is raising her grandson Tyler, who is nine. Her look-back shows that his mom's Sunday call fell through three times this month. She can't fix that. So she plans those evenings instead, with hot chocolate and his soccer annual, and asks her brother to take Tyler swimming on Sunday afternoons, so there's something to look forward to that doesn't depend on a phone ringing.

WORDS YOU COULD USE, WITH THE CHILD

"Mom loves you. She isn't well enough to look after you right now, and that's not your fault."

More for your situation

A look-back works in every kind of relationship, with small changes. Start from your relationship lists pages for each one.

- More than two partners · Money together · Gaming and time together · Sharing a room
- Foster and kinship families · When a child has ADHD · Grown-up children · Family rifts · Empty nest
- Different hours · Coming home · When one of you is sick · Two faiths · On my own · For counselors

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Start from your relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

ONLINE
More than two partners
spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two

ONLINE
Money together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together

ONLINE
Gaming and time together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together



TOOL
Plan it once: room agreement for roommates
spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room



ONLINE
Foster and kinship families
spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship



ONLINE
When a child has ADHD
spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids



ONLINE
Grown-up children
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children



ONLINE
Family rifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts



ONLINE
Empty nest
spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest



ONLINE
Different hours
spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours



ONLINE
Coming home
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home



ONLINE
When one of you is sick
spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill



ONLINE
Two faiths
spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths



ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own



ONLINE
For counselors
spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors

On your own: a monthly look at yourself

Once a month, look back at your own month kindly, more like a weather report than a scorecard. What filled your battery and what drained it? Which of your limits held and which slipped? Choose one small thing to keep and one to change. Rhiannon lives on her own after a divorce, and her look-back showed the same ✗ three weeks running. She'd skipped her Thursday swim to answer work emails, every week, telling herself it was just this once. So she moved the emails to Friday morning, and kept the swim (see On my own).

To begin, put a relaxed twenty-minute date in the calendar once a month and keep your weekly notes somewhere you can both find them. At the look-back, start by naming one thing that went well, and end by writing down how many gaps of each kind you found, so that over the next few months you can see whether the number is falling. What keeps coming back? is the workpaper for that conversation.

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-04 · free to print
What keeps coming back?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Weekly check-ins miss patterns.
- ✓ Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped.
- ✓ Sort each repeat into one of three kinds.
- ✓ Look back even when nothing is slipping.
- ✓ Keep it short and kind.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 1, Chapter 3 · Who you are becoming
The same kind look, on your own
Know Yourself Kindly, page 45

Book 2, Chapter 6 · Habits and change
Why problems come back, and how habits stick
Heal and Steady, page 101

Chapter 2 · Is the split working?
The setup score the look-back feeds
page 27

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 6: make it last
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

What keeps coming back? A monthly look-back
Workpaper · free to print
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-5-in-depth

BOOK 4 · AFTERWORD

What the series adds up to

A short look back over the whole series: what each book in the series was for, the few ideas that run through all of them, and where to go next.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Different books, one idea
2. Six threads through the series
3. Where to go from here

AT A GLANCE

- **Book 1 was about you**, where your lens came from, how you are wired and who you are becoming.
- **Book 2 was about steadying yourself** through stress, anger, worry, grief and change.
- **Book 3 was about understanding the people around you**, from how words land to why groups pull so hard.
- **Book 4 was about sharing the work of a shared life**, fairly and without keeping score.
- **A few habits run through all of them**: notice before you judge, settle before you speak, say it plainly, take small steps, repair, and look after your own part.

You don't need to have read every book in the series, or even all of this one, to get something from these last pages. Most people read in whatever order their life asks for, which is fine by me. I wrote them so you could start anywhere, stop anywhere, and pick them up again a year later with a cup of tea and no guilt.

Different books, one idea

Know Yourself Kindly came first because everything else leans on it. It looked at the lens you see through, at where your lens came from (Book 1, Chapter 1, page 7) and how you are wired today (Book 1, Chapter 2, page 25), and at how feelings, worth, personality and different minds work. It's hard to share a life well with no idea how you work yourself.

Heal and Steady was for the heavy days. It explained what stress does to the body (Book 2, Chapter 1, page 7), what anger is for, how worry and low mood work, and it walked through grief, repair, change and what matters to you.

Understanding Each Other turned outward, to why two kind people fall out of tune, how a message travels from one mind to another, why two people see the same moment so differently (Book 3, Chapter 3, page 45), and how belonging, love, groups and helping work.

Share the Load, this one, looked at the quiet work of running a home, a family or a team. How to see it. How to share it fairly. How to talk about it without anyone ending up in the dock.

Underneath all of them there's one idea, and if you forget everything else I'd keep this. Most of what goes wrong between people can be understood, and a good deal of it can be put right, mostly by seeing a bit more clearly and acting a bit more kindly, slightly more often than before. That's the whole idea. It took a whole series to say because the slightly-more-often is the hard part.

Six threads through the series

The five big ideas at the front of each book (*see the whole load*, *fix the setup rather than the person*, *read your state first*, *tune how you send and receive* and *notice the quiet incentives*) come down, in daily life, to a handful of habits, with one rule around all of them.

01

Notice before you judge.

A sharp word, a forgotten job, a quiet evening. There's nearly always a reason. Tiredness, a full stress tank, a different family rule, a different kind of mind. Ask what might be going on before you decide what's wrong with someone. How we see each other (Book 3, Chapter 3, page 45) goes into this.

02

Settle before you speak.

Nobody listens well with a flooded body. Breathe out slowly, step away with a time to come back, and talk after. Stress and the nervous system (Book 2, Chapter 1, page 7) and Anger (Book 2, Chapter 2, page 27) show how.

03

Say it plainly and kindly.

What happened, how it felt, what you're asking for. How communication works (Book 3, Chapter 2, page 23) has the details, and the grumpy-voice test, which I still think is the best four seconds in the series.

04

Small steps beat big pushes.

One job with one owner. One walk. One message on a Sunday. Most change that lasts starts like that, small and repeated until it's boring. Habits and change (Book 2, Chapter 6, page 101) and Is the

split working? (Chapter 2, page 27) both rest on it.

05

Repair is normal.

Everyone gets it wrong, often, me included. What keeps relationships going is coming back, with a short, real apology and a plan for next time, as Healing after hurt (Book 2, Chapter 5, page 81) describes.

06

Your part, and only your part.

You can change what you do. You can't make anyone else change.

Where to go from here

If you'd like a next step, here are a few, and you only need one. On your own, the self path turns Book 1 into a few steps at your own pace. With someone else, the six-week program turns this book into one small step a week, for a home, a family or a team, and it doesn't mind if you miss a week. If you have a question about anything in the series, Professor Puddles answers on the website. The research behind this book lists every study the series draws on, in plain words, with how strong the evidence is, and every chapter has a fuller version online, listed at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book.

ANY DAY, ANY TIME

You close the book. Nothing at home has changed yet. The mail is probably still on the table and somebody has probably still not took the trash out. Next Tuesday, maybe, a sharp word will land, and you'll wonder what's under it, or breathe out first, or say the thing plainly, or say sorry a bit sooner than you used to. Or you won't, and you'll notice afterward, and that counts too.

This book is general education, not therapy.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
the self path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

ONLINE
the six-week program
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

TOOL
Ask Professor Puddles
spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

ONLINE
spreadloveandacceptance.com/book
spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 1, Chapter 1 · Where your lens came from — Know Yourself Kindly, page 7
Start again at the beginning, on your own

Chapter 1 · The work nobody sees — page 7
Start the shared part, with someone

Book 1, Chapter 4 · How feelings work — Know Yourself Kindly, page 61
Start the background chapters

PUT IT TO USE



The self path

spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path



The six-week program

spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/afterword-in-depth

Your first month, week by week

If you would like an order to follow, here is one. Each week takes a few minutes a day at most, and a missed week is fine. The six-week program on the website does the same at a gentler pace.

WHEN	WHAT TO DO	READ MORE	DONE
Week 1	See the work. Each of you fills in Who did what for one ordinary week, writing only what you did yourself.	The work nobody sees (Chapter 1, page 7)	☐
Week 2	Give every job a name. Go through the job list on the next pages together and use One owner per job to agree an owner for each.	Is the split working? (Chapter 2, page 27)	☐
Week 3	Check the tanks. Each of you fills in How much are you carrying? on two or three days, then work out the setup score with the setup calculator or on paper.	Full tanks and different angles (Chapter 3, page 51)	☐
Week 4	Look back together. Sit down for twenty minutes with What keeps coming back?, choose one small change, and put the next look-back in the diary.	The monthly look-back (Chapter 5, page 97)	☐

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
six-week program
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

WORKPAPER WP-01 · free to print
Who did what
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01

WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

WORKPAPER WP-02 · free to print
How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02



TOOL
Fair split check: this week
spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working



WORKPAPER WP-04 · free to print
What keeps coming back?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04

A list of jobs to start from

Most homes share some of these. Tick the ones that happen in yours, cross out the rest and add your own at the bottom. Then give each ticked job one owner and, if you like, a backstop who notices if it slips, as in Is the split working? (Chapter 2, page 27). The same list is in the Quick look tool on the website, under Who does what? Quick look, and the workpaper One owner per job has room for the names.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Who does what? Quick look
spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand

WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

☐ happens in our home ..... owner

HOME AND FOOD

- [ ] Dishes and the kitchen reset
- [ ] Laundry and drying
- [ ] Folding and putting away
- [ ] Changing the sheets
- [ ] Cleaning the bathroom
- [ ] Vacuuming and floors
- [ ] Tidying up
- [ ] Trash and recycling
- [ ] Cooking dinner
- [ ] Meal planning
- [ ] Grocery shopping
- [ ] Packing lunches
- [ ] Restocking soap, paper and supplies
- [ ] Small fixes around the home
- [ ] Plants and the yard

MONEY AND ADMIN

- [ ] Paying bills
- [ ] Budget and checking accounts
- [ ] Taxes and receipts
- [ ] Post and home email
- [ ] Phone calls and customer service
- [ ] Insurance and documents
- [ ] Renewals and switching plans
- [ ] The car

CHILDREN

- [ ] Getting the kids up and ready
- [ ] School or daycare runs
- [ ] Homework help
- [ ] Bath time
- [ ] Bedtime
- [ ] Driving to activities
- [ ] School forms and sign-ups
- [ ] Playdates and parties
- [ ] Night wakings
- [ ] Childcare and backup plans

CARE AND HEALTH

- [ ] Booking appointments
- [ ] Medicines and refills
- [ ] Health appointments and calls
- [ ] Being on call for someone who is unwell
- [ ] Personal care (bathing, dressing)

PETS

- [ ] Feeding the pets
- [ ] Dog walks
- [ ] Litter, cage or tank
- [ ] Vet visits and pet supplies

FAMILY AND FRIENDS

- [ ] Keeping up with both families
- [ ] Birthdays and vacations
- [ ] Gifts and cards
- [ ] Hosting visitors
- [ ] Planning time with friends
- [ ] Planning trips and vacations

THE THINKING WORK

- [ ] Noticing what's running low
- [ ] Planning the week
- [ ] Remembering dates and appointments
- [ ] Keeping the family calendar
- [ ] Keeping track of the kids' stuff
- [ ] Checking that things got done
- [ ] Checking in on how people are

YOUR OWN

- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]

Words for the talk

Some ways to say the hard parts, collected in one place. Change the words until they sound like you.

TO BEGIN

> "Can we look at how the week went, together? I'd like us both to see it."
>
> "I've written down what I did this week. Would you do the same, so we can compare?"
>
> "Is now a good time, or would after dinner be better?"
>
> "I think a lot of the remembering lands on me. Can we talk about that?"

WHEN IT GETS TENSE

> "I'm getting wound up. Can we stop for twenty minutes and come back at eight?"
>
> "That came out sharper than I meant. Let me try again."
>
> "My tank is pretty full today, so I might sound crosser than I feel."
>
> "What did you hear me say?"

HANDING OVER A JOB

> "Could you own the trash from now on, from noticing they're full to putting them out?"
>
> "It's yours now, so do it your way. I'll only step in if you ask."
>
> "I'll be the backstop this month. If it slips, I'll mention it once, gently."

SAYING NO KINDLY

> "That's a fair ask. I can't take it on this week, but I could do Saturday's shop instead."
>
> "I'm at my limit. Can we look at what else could drop?"

THANKS AND CHECKING IN

> "Thanks for sorting the dentist. I noticed."
>
> "What's one thing that felt easier this month?"
>
> "Is anything from last week still sitting with you?"

Questions people ask

Some questions this book tends to raise, with short answers and where to read more.

My partner thinks the split is already fair. Where do we start?

With a week of facts. Fill in Who did what for one ordinary week, each of you writing only what you did yourself, and look at it together over a cup of tea. The planning and remembering often surprises both people. The work nobody sees (Chapter 1, page **7**) explains why, and Is the split working? (Chapter 2, page **27**) has a part for when only one of you wants to try.

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-01 · free to print
Who did what
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01

There are three or more of us. Does any of this still work?

Yes. Roommates, families with older children and teams can all use the same pages. Compare each person's share with an even share, which is 100 divided by the number of people, or with the split you agreed. "How the numbers work" at the back of this book (page **136**) shows the sums.

One of us works much longer paid hours. Is it fair to count only housework?

It isn't, and the book doesn't. If you have agreed an uneven split at home because one of you works longer hours outside it, the setup score compares against that agreement instead of an even split. Two kinds of fair (Chapter 4, page **73**) explains the difference between fair by results and fair by promises.

Can children have jobs with an owner too?

They can own jobs that suit their age, with an adult as the backstop who notices if it slips. Owning one small job from start to finish, such as feeding the cat or packing a school bag, is a good first step. Keep the planning and remembering with the adults until a child is ready for a piece of it, and say thank you out loud.

Talking about chores always turns into a fight. What can we do?

Pick a calm time, never the moment something has been left undone. Check how full each of your stress tanks is first, because a full tank makes every word land harder. Full tanks and different angles (Chapter 3, page 51) shows how, and The monthly look-back (Chapter 5, page 97) gives you a short, regular time to talk so that nothing has to wait for an argument.

Does this work at work, in a team?

Yes. The same quiet jobs exist at work, such as booking the room, chasing the late reply and noticing that the printer is out of paper, and a named owner and a real thank-you help there too. Most of the pages in this book work for a team with the word “home” swapped for “work.”

Workpapers and tools in this book

Every workpaper and tool this book points to, in two separate lists, with the chapters and pages that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Workpapers mentioned in this book

Pages to fill out, on your own or together.

WORKPAPER WP-01 **Who did what** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-01

In: The work nobody sees (page 7), Is the split working? (page 27), The monthly look-back (page 97), Your first month, week by week (page 125), Questions people ask (page 131)

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02

In: Is the split working? (page 27), Full tanks and different angles (page 51), The monthly look-back (page 97), Your first month, week by week (page 125)

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03

In: Is the split working? (page 27), Two kinds of fair (page 73), The monthly look-back (page 97), Your first month, week by week (page 125), A list of jobs to start from (page 127)

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-04

In: The monthly look-back (page 97), Your first month, week by week (page 125)

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09

In: Two kinds of fair (page 73)

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11

In: Full tanks and different angles (page 51)

Tools mentioned in this book

Interactive helpers to use on the site.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder`
In: Full tanks and different angles (page 51)

TOOL **Kitchen-table check-in** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins`
In: The monthly look-back (page 97)

TOOL **Small wins: Flip it** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins`
In: Two kinds of fair (page 73)

TOOL **Old rules, new choices** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up`
In: Full tanks and different angles (page 51)

TOOL **Who does what? Quick look** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand`
In: The work nobody sees (page 7), A list of jobs to start from (page 127)

TOOL **Who does what? Count the hours and bills** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand`
In: Is the split working? (page 27), Two kinds of fair (page 73)

TOOL **My weather today** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks`
In: Full tanks and different angles (page 51)

TOOL **My weather today: the sky (the ladder)** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks`
In: Full tanks and different angles (page 51)

TOOL **Ask Professor Puddles** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask`
In: What the series adds up to (page 119)

TOOL **Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting`
In: Is the split working? (page 27), Full tanks and different angles (page 51), Two kinds of fair (page 73), The monthly look-back (page 97)

TOOL **Plan it once: room agreement for roommates** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room`
In: Full tanks and different angles (page 51), Two kinds of fair (page 73), The monthly look-back (page 97)

TOOL **Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/work`
In: Is the split working? (page 27)

TOOL **Fair split check: this week** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working`

In: Is the split working? (page 27), Your first month, week by week (page 125)

How the numbers work

Every number in this book is arithmetic you can do with a pencil. None of them is a test, a diagnosis or a verdict on anyone: they describe a week, a load or a way of sharing work. The weights and cut-offs are this book's own rules of thumb, not research findings, and you are free to disagree with them. The worked examples are the book's own, so you can check them against the chapters.

Two habits run through all of them. **Scores are rounded to two decimal places before their band is read,** so the number you see and the words you see always agree. And **nobody's score is ever worked out for them:** if someone's own answer is missing, the total waits.

The stress tank: How much are you carrying?

You score five things from 0 (not at all) to 4 (very true), about the last day or two: sleep debt, workload elsewhere, unresolved conflict, your physical state, and time pressure today.

```
tank = (sleep + workload + conflict + body + time) ÷ 20
```

The answer runs from 0 to 1, and **higher means fuller**. Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 up to 0.60 medium, and 0.60 or more high. (The worksheet splits each band in two for its words: very light under 0.15, light, medium on the lighter side under 0.45, medium on the heavier side, high under 0.80, and very high from 0.80.) Your **battery** is the other side of the same thing, the energy you have left, so a full tank means a low battery. The battery is a picture in words, not a second score.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosa, from Chapter 3, page **51**, scores sleep 3, workload 4, conflict 1, body 2 and time 3.

`3 + 4 + 1 + 2 + 3 = 13; 13 ÷ 20 = 0.65`, which is in the high band.

Two or more of you: each person scores only themselves, and the shared figure is the plain average of everyone's own scores. If any one person is at 0.60 or more, treat that as the headline, whatever the average says.

Coming back after a pause (the Calm-Down Kit): if you like numbers, take the score again after a calming round. Under 0.50, go back at the time you named. From 0.50 to 0.59, take another round. At 0.60 or more after two rounds, put it off to a named time. The kit's line sits at 0.50 on purpose: you don't need an empty tank to come back, just one less than half full.

My weather today: the room in your day

My weather today shows words, not numbers: a sky (clear, gusty or fogged in) and how much room you have today. Behind the words sits a rough tally from 0 to 100, where **higher means a heavier day**. You only see it if you tick "Show the numbers behind this."

WHAT YOU PICKED	ADDS
The sky: clear, gusty, fogged in	0, 26, 34
The pressure: light, building, heavy (skipped: 6)	0, 10, 20
Last night's sleep: properly rested, about enough, short night, barely slept (skipped: 6)	0, 2, 10, 18
People load: barely any, a normal amount, a lot, nonstop (skipped: 4)	0, 3, 9, 14
Ground conditions (hungry, thirsty, in pain and so on)	4 each, up to 14
What's blowing in (work, money, health and so on)	3 each, up to 10

Under 45 reads as lots of room today, 45 to 64 as some room, and 65 or more as very little room.

WORKED EXAMPLE Joel, from Book 1, Chapter 2, page 25, picks gusty, building pressure, a short night, a lot of people time, one ground condition (hungry) and one thing blowing in (work).

`26 + 10 + 10 + 9 + 4 + 3 = 62`: some room today, with less than usual, so the forecast says to go gently and settle first.

Workload balance: how evenly the hours are shared

Two people. Work out each person's share of the logged hours as a percentage.

```
balance = 1 − (the difference between the two percentages ÷
100)
```

50/50 scores 1.00; one person doing everything scores 0.00. It doesn't matter which of you does more. Balance ignores the total, which is one reason the stress tank sits beside it.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary logs 14 hours and Ken 10 (Chapter 2, page **27**). Out of 24 hours, that is 58.3% and 41.7%.

`1 − (58.3 − 41.7) ÷ 100 = 1 − 0.167 = 0.83`

Three or more people, or an agreed split. The same idea, said more generally: how much of the week would have to change hands to reach the target, compared with the most that ever could.

```
each share = that person's hours ÷ everyone's hours
target     = an even share (1 ÷ number of people), or the split
you agreed
moved      = ½ × the sum of every |share − target|
most       = 1 − the smallest target share
balance    = 1 − moved ÷ most
```

WORKED EXAMPLE Three partners log 15, 9 and 6 hours (Chapter 2, page **27**): shares 0.50, 0.30 and 0.20, against a third each.

`moved = ½ × (0.167 + 0.033 + 0.133) = 0.167, most = 1 − 0.333 = 0.667, and balance = 1 − 0.167 ÷ 0.667 = 0.75`. In hours, 0.167 × 30 = 5 hours a week would change hands for an even split.

With an agreed split, use it as the target: co-parents who agreed 60/40 and log 12 and 8 hours score 1.00.

Ownership: does every job have a name?

```
ownership = jobs with a named owner ÷ all the jobs on the list
```

The calculator counts a job as owned when it has one named owner. A backstop, the person who notices if it slipped, is a good habit and has its own column, but the score only needs the owner. The starter jobs on the worksheet don't count until you give them an owner or change them. Never raise the score by deleting the jobs nobody owns: they are exactly what the score is there to show.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary and Ken list 12 regular jobs, and 9 have an owner: `9 ÷ 12 = 0.75`.

Who carries more of the list. A score of 1.00 can still mean one person owns everything, so One owner per job also shows each person's share of the list, with each job weighted by how often it comes round and how big it is:

```
weight of a job = how often × size
how often: daily 5, weekly 1, ongoing 1, monthly 0.25, as
needed 0.1
size:      small 0.5, medium 1 (the default), big 2
           (or, where you gave the hours each time: hours ÷
0.5)
share      = the weights of that person's jobs ÷ the weights of
all the jobs
```

A job you decide together counts the same for each of you; on a list for two homes it shows as "Together" instead.

WORKED EXAMPLE One person owns the cooking (daily, medium: 5) and the bills (monthly, medium: 0.25). The other owns the laundry (weekly, big: 2) and the car (as needed, medium: 0.1). Each owns two jobs, but `5.25 ÷ 7.35 = 71%` of the list's weight sits with the first person, and 29% with the second.

Who's carrying more right now. Who did what flags the busiest person when their share of the logged minutes (or of the work done without being asked) is at least half, and at least 20 points over an even share: 70% or more for two people, 53% or more for three. In the example in Chapter 1, page **7**, one partner did 105 of the 115 minutes that were noticed and handled without anyone asking: 91%, so the sheet says so.

The setup score: can the way you share the work last?

```
setup score = balance × 0.40
            + ownership × 0.35
            + (1 − the average tank score) × 0.25
```

The weights add up to 1, so the score runs from 0 to 1, and here **higher means the setup is working better**, the opposite of the tank score. The tank is the only part that counts against the score, which is why it enters as 1 − tank. 0.70 or more reads as working well (the "Who does what?" page says "holding"). From 0.40 up to 0.70 it reads as needs a look ("drifting"), and below 0.40 as needs a rethink, together. It is a snapshot of the setup, never a probability and never a verdict on anyone.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary and Ken (Chapter 2, page **27**): balance 0.83, ownership 0.75, and their own tank scores are 0.45 and 0.30, an average of 0.375.

`0.83 × 0.40 + 0.75 × 0.35 + (1 − 0.375) × 0.25 = 0.333 + 0.263 + 0.156 = 0.75`: working well.

The shortfall is what each part could have earned minus what it did earn: balance 0.40 − 0.333 = 0.067, ownership 0.35 − 0.263 = 0.088, and tank 0.25 − 0.156 = 0.094. The biggest shortfall is the tank, which usually eases outside the chore list (more sleep, a lighter week elsewhere). The calculator's "what would help most" is the single change with the biggest gain: handing about 2 hours a week from Rosemary to Ken would take balance from 0.83 to 1.00, worth 0.067. Naming one more job's owner would be worth 0.029, and a tank score lower by 0.10 on average 0.025.

The 30-day look-back: what shifted this month?

The look-back splits the last 30 days into four weeks (the first takes the first ten days). For each part you filled in (balance, ownership, the stress tank, and last-minute rescues), it compares the start of the month with the end:

```
start = the average of weeks 1 and 2
end   = the average of weeks 3 and 4
it shifted if end − start is 0.10 or more (balance, ownership,
tank),
           or 1 a week or more (rescues); anything smaller
didn't shift
```

One next step: a part that moved the wrong way comes first (the biggest move for its size). Otherwise, the first of these that is still true at the end: ownership under 0.70, balance under 0.70, 2 or more rescues a week, or anyone's tank at 0.60 or more. If none is, keep the same rhythm and look again in 30 days.

Hours to change hands over the month: for each person, the hours they did minus their share of everyone's hours, added up week by week. Half the sum of those gaps (ignoring the minus signs) is how many hours would change hands to make the month even.

WORKED EXAMPLE Suppose Rosemary and Ken keep going for a month (made up, like them). Their four weeks look like this. Hours: 14 and 10, 15 and 9, 13 and 11, 12 and 12. Jobs with an owner: 9, 9, 11 and 11 of 12. Rosemary's tank: 0.45, 0.50, 0.40 and 0.35, and Ken's 0.30 every week. Rescues: 3, 2, 1 and 1.

PART	START (WEEKS 1–2)	END (WEEKS 3–4)	CHANGE	READS AS
Balance	(0.83 + 0.75) ÷ 2 = 0.79	(0.92 + 1.00) ÷ 2 = 0.96	+0.17	Better
Ownership	0.75	0.92	+0.17	Better
Average tank score	0.39	0.34	−0.05	About the same
Rosemary's own tank	0.48	0.38	−0.10	Lighter
Rescues a week	2.5	1	−1.5	Fewer

Three of the four parts shifted, all for the better, and nothing is left on the watch list, so the next step is to keep the rhythm. The setup score went from 0.73 to 0.87. Over the month Rosemary did 54 hours and Ken 42, so 6 hours would have changed hands for an even month.

On your own: is your week sustainable?

The “Who does what?” page’s “just me” view adds up the hours your week is spoken for (jobs, the thinking work, care and so on) and compares them with a waking week of about 112 hours (16 waking hours, 7 days).

```
share = the hours spoken for ÷ 112
```

Under 50% reads as sustainable, 50% up to 70% as full but workable, and 70% or more as stretched. For example, 50 hours spoken for is 45%, which leaves real room; 80 hours is 71%, a lot to keep up week after week.

All of these are this book’s own ways of putting things into numbers. They have not been tested in research studies, and they shouldn’t be quoted as findings. The free calculators on the website do the arithmetic for you, and each one has a “How is this worked out?” note.

Words used in this book

The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. All of them are at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.

Backstop

The second name on a job: someone who notices if it slipped and checks in kindly. Not a supervisor. A job counts as owned once it has an owner; the backstop is a good habit on top.

Battery

Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, how full your stress tank is: a fuller tank means a lower battery.

Check-in

A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

Complacency

Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.

Flooded

Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

Gatekeeping

Holding on to how a home or child-care job must be done, so the other person steps back. Researchers first described it in mothers ("maternal gatekeeping"), but anyone can do it.

Kinship care

When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

The ladder

Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. My weather today calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

Ledger

A notebook where you write down what happened, so you can look at it calmly later. The book works the same way: see what is really going on, without blame, then change one small thing.

The load

The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

Mental load

The noticing, planning and remembering behind running a shared life: knowing the shoes are too small, booking the appointment, keeping the list. It is real work, even though nobody sees it.

My weather today

My weather today is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

Parallel parenting

Co-parenting with as little direct contact as possible: each home runs its own way, and messages stay short, polite and about the children.

Pressure

Pressure, in My weather today, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

Setup score

The one number from Is the setup working for everyone?: balance, ownership and stress added up with weights (0.40, 0.35 and 0.25), from 0 to 1. 0.70 and up is working well, 0.40 to 0.69 needs a look, under 0.40 needs a rethink, together. It judges the setup, never a person.

Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?, scored from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 to 0.59 medium, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

Unbilled debt

Unbilled debt is the work of a shared life that got done but was never noticed or thanked.

Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

Workpaper

A page you fill in, on your own or with someone, about your own week or your own side. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill out on the website.

Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

How the ideas connect

Thirteen fields of study turn up in this book, and underneath them the same seven roots keep showing through. Learn a root once and you can carry it from one field to the next: if a budget needs a safety margin, so does a tired person.

Neurobiology
Your state sets the volume.
Chapter 3

Psychology
Intent isn't impact.
Chapter 3

Philosophy
Separate the fact from the guess.
Chapter 4

The art of debating
Separate the claim from the person.
Chapter 4

Politics
A fair way to decide, and a say for everyone.
Chapter 2

THE SEVEN ROOTS

Balance what flows in has to match what flows out 1, 4

Signal and noise what's sent isn't always what arrives 3, 4

Feedback loops small things repeated, with a check each time, shape the whole 5

Limited capacity everything has a limit 1

Ownership and structure work that belongs to everyone belongs to no one 2, 5

Quiet incentives things drift toward whatever the setup quietly rewards 2

State and setting the same message lands differently depending on the state you're in and the place you're in 3

Behavioral science
Habits beat good intentions.
Chapter 5

Economics
Attention is a budget.
Chapter 1

Finance
Every entry has two sides.
Chapter 1

Business
One owner per job, and a simple check.
Chapter 1

Holistic therapies
Start with the body, then the argument.
Chapter 5

Laughter therapy
A shared laugh tells the body it's safe.
Chapter 5

Music
Tone and tempo carry more than the words.
Chapter 4

Aromatherapy
The setting matters.
Chapter 3

Holistic therapies, laughter and aromatherapy appear only in their plain, everyday parts; the research on them is modest or still growing.

Research notes



The 71 studies and books these chapters mention, briefly. Each one was looked up and checked. The full list, with what each study found, how strong the finding is and where to read it, is free online: spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

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Six calm classic games, including the Home Run Derby. Play as either pup, and there's no game over.

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A cozy 3D coin pusher. Every five coins that drop bring a short, useful tip.

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The Night Garden

A calm breathing game. A flower blooms with every slow breath, and there are fireflies to guide and a lily pond to fill.

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The Logic Behind It: more examples, free online

Most of the "Two ways to read this" boxes in this book hold a situation from a free page on the website. It has more than seventy everyday reactions that can look odd or over the top from outside, each laid out in the same six parts, with the other person's side and one small step.

You can type what happened in your own words and see the closest situations, pick another picture when the first doesn't click, and build a card of your own. It is free, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.

The pocket guide in this series, *The Logic Behind It*, collects 38 of them in print, one to a page.



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The series

Spread Love & Acceptance is a series of short books. Each one stands on its own; read them in any order.

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Book 2	**Heal and Steady** For the heavy days: stress, anger, worry and low mood, grief, repair, change and what matters to you.
Book 3	**Understanding Each Other** Pace and tone, how words land, how we see each other, belonging, love, groups and helping well.
Book 4	**Share the Load** *(this book)* For homes, families and teams: seeing the unseen work, one owner per job, and two kinds of fair.
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Pocket guide	**The Logic Behind It** Thirty-eight everyday reactions, one to a page, with the logic behind each one and a kind next step.

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Your notes

For what you want to remember, try or ask about.